

Political Brokerage as a Profession: Evidence from Mexico

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May 2026

Abstract

Political brokers are central actors in developing-world democracies, yet little is known about their long-run careers. We fielded an original life-history survey of former precinct chiefs of a major Mexican party, combining two official rosters with a matched sample of party sympathizers and a representative state-level survey. We show that political brokerage is a durable profession, with average tenures exceeding two decades. Brokers report greater early political ambition and family activism than sympathizers, but do not come from more advantaged socioeconomic backgrounds. Brokers are poorer than both sympathizers and the broader population living in the same state. Compared to sympathizers, they show little evidence of greater economic mobility across income, housing, job status, and wealth, while origin–destination patterns reveal both upward and downward movement, with more negative trajectories for women. Politically, brokers exhibit stronger partisan identification but rarely convert their political engagement into elected office. By recasting brokerage as a profession, the study broadens theories of political careers and class representation beyond formal officeholders and offers a replicable approach for studying hard-to-reach political populations.

Word Count: 8,903

This study has been approved by the Harvard Institutional Review Board (Protocol IRB20-2038). Pablo Balán acknowledges funding from the Weatherhead Center for International Affairs at Harvard University.

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1 Introduction

In many developing-world democracies, local intermediaries—commonly known as brokers—help organize political life ([Eisenstadt and Roniger, 1984](#); [Lemarchand, 1972](#); [Scott, 1972](#)). They help provide public goods ([Baldwin, 2015](#)), mediate access to welfare and services ([Auerbach, 2016](#); [Rizzo, 2024](#); [Garay et al., 2020](#)), solve problems ([Auyero, 2001](#); [Szwarcberg, 2012, 2015](#)), and mobilize electoral support ([Díaz-Cayeros et al., 2016](#); [Stokes, 2005](#); [Stokes et al., 2013](#)).

Yet we know surprisingly little about brokers’ careers and long-term prospects. While the literature has long recognized the long-term relationships between brokers and citizens ([Auyero, 2001](#)), it has largely overlooked brokers’ long-term careers. Brokers constitute a political workforce ([Zarazaga, 2014](#); [Tsai, 2007](#); [Auerbach and Thachil, 2023](#)). Studies of mass parties have long emphasized their reliance on stable organizational personnel ([Levitsky, 2001](#); [Panebianco, 1988](#)), and resource-based accounts acknowledge parties’ need for individuals who manage, organize, and run activities ([Cyr, 2017](#); [Greene, 2007](#)). Yet brokers’ work trajectories have received surprisingly little attention.³

In this article, we address this oversight and study political brokerage as a profession. We argue—and establish empirically—that brokerage is a long-term career, with tenure spanning roughly a quarter century. If brokerage is a stable occupation, it should attract particular types of individuals and shape their long-term trajectories. Although brokers are the most common type of politician in the developing world, brokerage as a profession may differ from political officeholding in both the types of individuals it attracts and the economic returns it generates. Brokers occupy an intermediate position between citizens and formal political elites—they are deeply embedded in party organizations and local political life. Because of this peculiar position, they may not convert political labor into elected office, bureaucratic incorporation, or sustained economic mobility. Without long-term studies of brokers’ careers, we lack evidence on how brokerage shapes brokers’

³A notable exception is [Brierley and Nathan \(2022\)](#); however, their research centers on how parties choose to advance different types of party members. Because they operate at the fringes of the formal state apparatus, political brokers occupy a blind spot in the literature on the personnel economics of the state ([Finan et al., 2017](#)).

own trajectories.

To address this blind spot, we conducted the first study of the long-run social and economic trajectories of political brokers. We surveyed former brokers, known as *precinct chiefs*, who worked for one of Mexico's largest and longest-serving political parties, the PRI, in the Mexican state of Nuevo León. These individuals were active as brokers approximately 20 years before the survey—an example of what is typically considered a hard-to-reach population.

We document three broad patterns. First, brokerage is highly durable: average tenure approaches a quarter-century, indicating that brokerage is not temporary political work but rather a long-term career. Second, brokers differ from otherwise similar party sympathizers well before entering brokerage, exhibiting greater political ambition at a young age. Third, despite their durable organizational role, brokers remain economically marginal and experience limited upward mobility compared to both party sympathizers and the comparison population.

Our key contribution is to recast brokerage as a durable occupation. Our life-history approach allows us to study both selection and long-term socioeconomic outcomes. Our findings contribute to two main literatures. First, we add to a robust literature on political intermediaries. This literature has predominantly focused on the relationship between brokers and parties ([Auerbach and Thachil, 2020](#); [Camp, 2015](#); [Langston and Castro Cornejo, 2023](#); [Larreguy et al., 2016](#)) and between brokers and voters ([Auyero, 2001](#); [Díaz-Cayeros et al., 2016](#); [Finan and Schechter, 2012](#); [Lawson and Greene, 2014](#); [Lomnitz, 1988](#); [Stokes, 2005](#); [Stokes et al., 2013](#)). Studies of brokers' monetary incentives have focused on compensation during and outside election seasons ([Brierley and Nathan, 2022](#)). Recent work on relational clientelism argues that clientelistic exchanges rely on stable intermediaries who sustain repeated exchanges with voters over time ([Nichter, 2018](#); [Yıldırım and Kitschelt, 2020](#)). We focus on an organizational consequence of relational clientelism: the extent to which it turns brokerage into a long-term profession.

Second, we contribute to research on the socioeconomic background of politicians ([Best and Cotta, 2000](#); [Carnes and Lupu, 2015](#); [Dal Bó et al., 2017](#); [Gulzar, 2021](#); [Kirkland, 2021](#); [Krcmaric et al., 2024](#); [Motolinia et al., 2025](#)) and the economic returns to officeholding ([Diermeier et al.,](#)

2005). Existing research on formal political institutions finds that politicians tend to come from higher-income backgrounds than the broader population (Carnes and Lupu, 2023). However, this literature has predominantly focused on advanced democracies (Gulzar, 2021). We extend this body of research beyond formal office-holders to political intermediaries, one of the most common political actors in developing countries (Eisenstadt and Roniger, 1984). We find a starkly different pattern among brokers. Brokers do not come from wealthier or more educated backgrounds than the comparison population, suggesting that gaps in class representation may be less pronounced outside formal political institutions. One possible reason is that “street-level” politicians rely less on socioeconomic differentiation and more on local embeddedness (Balán et al., 2022; Baldwin and Raffler, 2019; Bhavnani and Lee, 2018; Kruks-Wisner, 2022; Szwarcberg, 2015). Embedded brokers are better positioned to sustain the relational ties that underpin long-term exchanges with citizens (Auyero, 2001; Díaz-Cayeros et al., 2016) and higher-level politicians. We also find that brokers display higher political ambition, family activism, and political discussion at home during childhood. We depart from recent work that finds limited class differences in nascent political ambition (Carnes and Lupu, 2025; Crowder-Meyer, 2020; Fox and Lawless, 2005). One possible explanation is that in weakly institutionalized settings such as informal political networks, personal characteristics play a larger role in shaping entry into politics (Gulzar, 2021).

Our goal is primarily descriptive. We do not claim to identify the causal effects of brokerage on socioeconomic mobility. Yet our approach allowed us to survey former brokers alongside two relevant comparison groups: party sympathizers and the comparison population in the same state. This design allows us to generate descriptive inferences about brokers’ long-run trajectories. Our study also speaks to the challenges of studying hard-to-reach political populations. Because of their age, location, and politically sensitive roles, former brokers are difficult to identify and survey. Whereas most work on hard-to-reach populations focuses on marginalized groups (Faugier and Sargeant, 1997; Jackson, 2025; Khoury, 2020), we study a politically connected population in a developing-country setting. Accessing this population posed substantial logistical challenges, similar to those encountered in studies of political elites (Kertzer and Renshon, 2022). More

broadly, our combination of an original survey, party rosters, matched comparison groups, and a weighted representative survey illustrates how researchers can use public and administrative data to improve comparability and strengthen descriptive inference about hard-to-reach political populations (de Kadt and Grzymała-Busse, 2026).

2 Brokerage as a Profession

Political brokers have received substantial scholarly attention (e.g., Stokes et al., 2013). Their electoral functions—mobilizing voters and distributing benefits—as well as their everyday role as local problem-solvers are well documented (Auyero, 2001; Zarazaga, 2014; Szwarcberg, 2012, 2015). Existing studies classify brokers by their organizational and party ties (Holland and Palmer-Rubin, 2015) or examine the conditions under which they remain loyal (Langston and Castro Cornejo, 2023), but rarely trace how brokerage shapes brokers’ own long-run socioeconomic trajectories. Recent work emphasizes the relational nature of many clientelistic exchanges (Higashijima and Washida, 2024; Nichter, 2018; Yildirim and Kitschelt, 2020). Relational clientelism is more prevalent when parties combine durable territorial organizations with sustained access to state resources, enabling repeated exchanges with voters over time (Yildirim and Kitschelt, 2020). Such systems rely on stable intermediaries who maintain long-term relationships with voters and distribute benefits over time. We focus on one overlooked organizational consequence of relational clientelism: the extent to which it turns brokerage into a durable occupation.

We treat brokerage as a profession in Weber’s sense: a durable occupation through which individuals live *off* politics (Weber, 1946). Weber distinguished those who live *off* politics—for whom political work is a sustained source of livelihood—from those who live *for* politics, engaging in politics out of conviction. Studies of parties and bureaucracies have examined the careers of elected officials, activists, and party elites, showing how political organizations shape recruitment, incentives, and advancement (Best and Cotta, 2000). Yet this literature has largely overlooked political intermediaries, despite their central role in organizing political life in many

developing democracies ([Eisenstadt and Roniger, 1984](#)).

Two implications follow. If brokerage is a profession rather than a temporary form of political labor, brokers are not merely fungible operatives ([Novaes, 2018](#)) but a distinct social group whose trajectories are worth examining. Second, this reframing speaks to research on the social backgrounds of politicians, which finds that officeholders are disproportionately drawn from privileged strata ([Carnes and Lupu, 2015, 2023](#)). While an expanding body of work focuses on formal political office, brokers are the most common type of politician in the developing world.

Treating brokerage as a profession suggests a distinct set of empirical expectations. Past work suggests that brokers enter politics through a different mechanism: brokerage relies on embeddedness—deep local ties and involvement in community life ([Auyero, 2001](#)). If so, brokerage should not primarily select on economic advantage, and class gaps in political representation may therefore differ from those observed in formal political office. Because embeddedness is built through years of community involvement, entry into brokerage may reflect early political socialization—political ambition, family activism, and a record of community problem-solving—rather than wealth or education. At the same time, embeddedness may be difficult to convert into broader economic or political advancement. If the value of brokerage lies in localized networks, party loyalty, and sustained neighborhood presence, brokerage may become a durable but weakly mobile career: brokers may remain strongly partisan and politically active for long periods without moving into formal office or experiencing substantial economic mobility. This organizational logic may also entail costs. Long-term investment in localized political work may foreclose alternative career paths, leaving professional brokers economically vulnerable despite their deep political incorporation.

These expectations concern long-tenure brokers, not everyone who occasionally mobilizes voters. Some individuals engage in brokerage sporadically while working primarily outside politics, and are therefore unlikely to experience substantial long-term occupational effects. Our focus is instead on brokers for whom political brokerage is a central and sustained activity ([Szwarcberg, 2015; Zarazaga, 2014](#)). Their trajectories may reveal how political organizations shape the long-

term careers of the workforce on which clientelistic politics depends.

3 Setting

3.1 The Mexican Context: Institutionalizing Neighborhood Brokers

With more than 70 years of continuous rule by a hegemonic party, Mexico offers an important case for studying institutionalized brokerage. As in much of Latin America, economic liberalization weakened corporatist party–labor linkages and expanded urban informality, increasing the importance of brokerage as a durable source of livelihood and political mediation (Levitsky, 2003; Langston, 2018). Political brokerage emerged as a profession embodied in roles such as *lidere-sas*, *jefes seccionales*, and *comisarios*. Precinct chiefs spent most of their time engaged in “social brokerage”—off-season mediation and service provision—which underpinned both their electoral effectiveness and their livelihoods (Rizzo, 2015).⁴

The institutionalization of brokerage accelerated during a period of political and economic transformation. In the late 1980s and early 1990s, facing growing electoral competition and weakening corporatist structures, the PRI reorganized its territorial structure to rebuild local organizational capacity. In 1989, the federal government, under President Carlos Salinas de Gortari, launched the Programa Nacional de Solidaridad (PRONASOL); the PRI’s territorial structure channeled its poverty-alleviation resources through newly formalized local leadership structures. This process reinforced the role of local intermediaries in distributing state resources.⁵ In the late 1990s, the PRI incorporated local leaders—also known as *jefes auxiliares* or *líderes de colonia*—and will-ing *caciques* into the formal party structure, assigning them responsibility for electoral precincts. The PRI referred to these local leaders as precinct chiefs (*jefes seccionales*).

In doing so, the PRI sought to improve the party’s targeting strategies by creating a network of

⁴While approximately 22 percent of Mexican voters report receiving gifts during elections (Nichter and Palmer-Rubin, 2015), and practices such as *acarreo* (transporting voters to polling stations) remain common, the literature’s focus on electoral moments risks obscuring the extent to which brokerage functions as a year-round occupation.

⁵For a detailed analysis of PRONASOL’s role in the PRI’s territorial reorganization and resource-distribution strategies, see Díaz-Cayeros et al. (2016).

locally embedded agents capable of allocating resources and persuading voters. By delimiting their jurisdictions, the PRI could also better monitor brokers' electoral performance (Larreguy et al., 2016), which became particularly important after the party faced its first competitive presidential election in 1988. Precinct chiefs were typically selected and legitimized in neighborhood meetings and charged with communicating local demands to higher-level party actors. While some precinct chiefs claim that their appointments can be revoked through elections, in most cases they were confirmed in their positions during neighborhood meetings. Interviews and data reported in Rizzo (2015) suggest a turnover rate of roughly 20 percent among PRI leaders; nonetheless, precinct chiefs were rarely removed and often held their positions for decades. For individuals who became precinct chiefs during this period, the late-1990s formalization turned local political activism into a long-term occupation tied to neighborhood life and local party networks.

3.2 Monterrey, Nuevo León

The state of Nuevo León, in northeastern Mexico, has a population of more than 5 million, most of whom reside in Monterrey, Mexico's ninth-largest metropolitan area. Highly industrialized, the state accounts for about 12 percent of Mexico's GDP and underwent rapid urbanization and industrial transformation during the late twentieth century. This makes Monterrey an especially appropriate site for studying brokers' trajectories: it was the setting of the classic Monterrey Mobility Study (Balán et al., 1973), a pioneering analysis of social mobility in twentieth-century Mexico. Studying broker trajectories here lets us benchmark them against a setting where Mexican social mobility has already been measured. The combination of rapid urbanization, industrialization, and the PRI's institutional reorganization made political brokerage a particularly viable source of livelihood for many residents of Monterrey's expanding neighborhoods.

4 Research Design

Our aim is descriptive. We document how brokers’ long-run social and economic trajectories differ from those of politically active non-brokers and from the comparison population of the same state. Because broker status is not randomly assigned, our results should be interpreted as controlled comparisons describing patterns of selection and long-term trajectories rather than the causal effects of brokerage. The central design challenge is therefore comparative: identifying plausible benchmarks against which to describe brokers’ long-run trajectories. We use two complementary comparisons. First, we compare brokers to party sympathizers drawn from the same local political environments. Second, we compare brokers to the comparison population of Nuevo León using a reweighted representative survey.

4.1 Data and Sampling

We use two previously untapped rosters produced by one of Mexico’s largest political parties. The first is the full list of precinct chiefs active in Nuevo León in 1997 (Roster 1; $N = 2,065$), which includes each broker’s name, phone number, address, and occupation as recorded on their voter ID. The second is a list of citizens who attended party rallies (Roster 2; $N \approx 800,000$). These individuals were not employed as brokers but can be understood as party sympathizers. Together, the two rosters define a broader population of party-connected citizens: some entered formal broker roles, while others remained politically active sympathizers.

We linked both rosters to the 2012 Nuevo León voter registry (*Lista Nominal*), which covers approximately 3.3 million voters and records sex, date of birth, municipality, and broad employment category. Sympathizer records include the unique voter registry code, allowing exact matches. Broker records lack this identifier, so we linked them using blocked approximate string matching, obtaining valid matches for 78% of the roster ($N = 1,604$).⁶

⁶Jaro–Winkler distance within municipality–district cells. We employed a conservative validation strategy: exact matches were automatically accepted; non-exact matches were retained only below a similarity threshold ($JW < 0.052$) calibrated through visual inspection. See Online Appendix (OA) Section A.1 for full matching details and

Reaching individuals listed in administrative records dating back more than two decades required a flexible sampling strategy. For brokers (Roster 1), we consolidated all available contact information, removed duplicates, and identified 2,065 unique entries. We randomly ordered the full broker roster and assigned cases sequentially to interviewers across three survey waves.⁷

Survey implementation proved difficult because the rosters were more than two decades old. Only 510 of 2,065 broker entries included a phone number; after excluding disconnected lines, deceased individuals, and numbers unreachable after repeated attempts, 139 remained as valid contacts, of whom 53 completed the interview. This represents a 38% response rate among valid contacts and 2.6% of the full roster (see OA Section A.8 and Figure A.1 for the full sampling flow from administrative records to final sample). The sympathizer roster posed similar challenges: only about 30% of listed phone numbers were valid. These constraints shaped the construction of the comparison group.

4.2 Comparison Groups

We use two comparison groups. The first compares brokers to politically active non-brokers drawn from the same local environment (electoral precincts). The second situates brokers relative to the broader comparison population. Using multiple comparison groups is standard in the study of political selection and careers. For example, Dal Bó et al. (2017) compare elected politicians to the general population, non-elected candidates, their siblings, and members of elite professions. Access to a comparison group of party sympathizers is especially valuable because it allows us to approximate “marginal types”—individuals who plausibly had a similar probability of becoming brokers but did not (Gulzar, 2021). Such “unseen politicians” (Fowler and McClure, 1989) are often more difficult to identify and reach than the population of interest.

Our second comparison uses the 2021 ESRU Survey of Social Mobility in Nuevo León (ESRU-anonymization procedures.

⁷The survey was administered by nine trained undergraduate enumerators from Instituto Tecnológico de Monterrey. Each received a project-specific SIM card, deactivated after survey completion. Enumerators submitted daily progress reports and were supervised through daily check-ins and call log review. See OA Sections A.3 and A.4 for full enumerator training and field protocols.

EMOVI), a representative survey of state residents aged 25–64 ($N = 3,767$) fielded by the Centro de Estudios Espinosa Yglesias ([Centro de Estudios Espinosa Yglesias, 2021](#)). We adapted the socioeconomic and mobility modules in our broker survey directly from EMOVI, allowing us to measure origin and destination status comparably across the two samples. We reweight EMOVI to match the brokers’ demographic profile by gender and municipality. This creates a population benchmark with the same observable composition as the broker sample. The weighting procedure, together with an assessment of cross-cohort comparability, is detailed in OA Section [A.9](#).

The primary goal of these comparisons is descriptive: to characterize brokers’ long-run trajectories in a comparable way. Party sympathizers provide a benchmark of politically active citizens drawn from the same precincts. The reweighted Nuevo León comparison population provides a demographically comparable benchmark with no necessary connection to politics. Both comparison groups were constructed to maximize comparability. Party sympathizers were sampled from the same electoral precincts as responding brokers, helping hold local context constant. The socioeconomic and mobility modules were adapted directly from the representative survey, so origin and destination status are measured equivalently across samples, strengthening the credibility of descriptive inference ([de Kadt and Grzymała-Busse, 2026](#)). While the design does not identify the causal effects of brokerage, it helps narrow plausible interpretations about the nature and extent of selection into brokerage versus the consequences of brokerage itself.

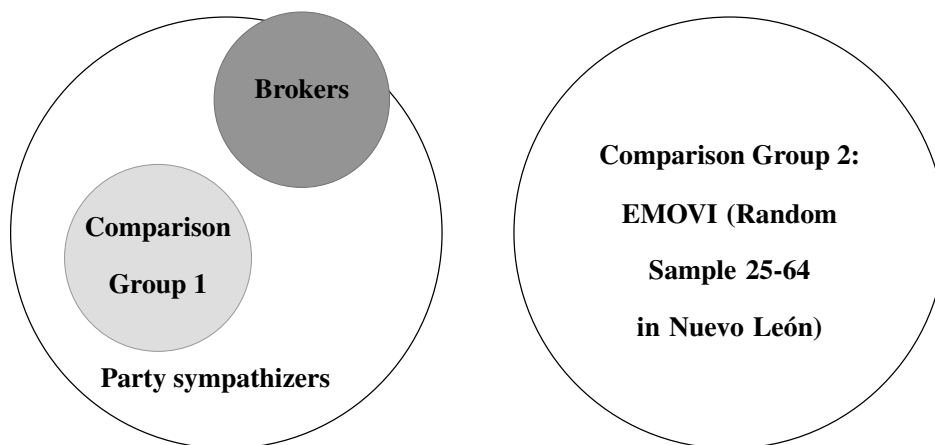
Ideally, we would randomly sample sympathizers matched to precinct chiefs on demographics, political histories, and location. Two constraints made this infeasible. First, the sympathizer list contains only age, gender, and last registered address. Second, the low response rate among brokers meant that a pre-specified random sample from the full sympathizer roster would have produced a large, heterogeneous comparison group relative to the small and geographically concentrated broker sample.

We therefore constructed the sympathizer sample after completing the broker interviews. After completing all broker interviews, we identified the electoral precincts and gender distribution of responding brokers and sampled control individuals from Roster 2 who matched these precinct-

by-gender combinations.⁸ This procedure produced a candidate pool of 5,562 individuals; 3,906 (70%) had a listed phone number, and 37 completed interviews.⁹

Response patterns may correlate with unobserved characteristics. Still, drawing sympathizers from the same precincts as responding brokers reduces the risk that differences reflect local context rather than broker status. Individuals in both rosters can be understood as members of a single population of party-connected citizens, only some of whom entered formal broker roles (Figure 1).

Figure 1: The three populations in our study



Notes: Brokers: precinct chiefs from Roster 1 ($N = 2,065$; surveyed $N = 53$). Comparison Group 1: party sympathizers from Roster 2 ($N \approx 800,000$; matched sample $N = 5,562$; surveyed $N = 37$). Comparison Group 2: EMOVI 2021, a representative survey of adults in Nuevo León ($N = 3,767$), reweighted to match the broker sample's demographic composition.

The final sample comprises 53 precinct chiefs and 37 party sympathizers (90 survey respondents), compared against the reweighted EMOVI benchmark ($N = 3,767$). Together, these data allow us to study three dimensions of brokerage: selection into broker roles, long-run political trajectories, and long-run socioeconomic mobility.

⁸We did not match on age, as doing so would have reduced the eligible pool substantially given the anticipated rate of invalid phone numbers.

⁹See OA Section A.2.2 for a detailed discussion of the matching rationale and logistical constraints.

4.3 Survey Instrument

We implemented a 30-minute phone-based life-history survey of both brokers and a sample of sympathizers. To build rapport, respondents were told that the research team was interested in their experiences as community organizers.¹⁰ The survey collected information on demographics, current and past political participation, household socioeconomic status at age 14 and at the time of the survey, employment, intergenerational educational attainment, social norms, and social networks. Full question wording for all variables used in the analysis is provided in OA Section A.5. Because precinct chiefs in the full roster average 66 years of age, questions about childhood circumstances required long-term recall. Such recall poses well-known challenges, since retrospective reports may be imperfect and systematically biased (Dex, 1995; Kjellsson et al., 2014; de Nicola and Giné, 2012). To address these concerns, we build on best practices from prior life-history survey approaches in similar contexts (Balán et al., 1969). We mitigated these concerns by using verbal cues to anchor respondents in specific life periods, maintaining parallel wording across time periods, and recording enumerator assessments of recall quality. Additional details are provided in OA Section A.4.

5 Results

5.1 Sample characteristics

Table 1 compares descriptive characteristics of precinct chiefs and party sympathizers. Precinct chiefs are, on average, significantly older (8.5 years) relative to party sympathizers. The fraction of female respondents is high in both groups (brokers: 69%, sympathizers 73%). Precinct chiefs have nearly 1.4 levels less formal education (1.40 on a 0–10 ordinal scale). There are no income differences at an early age. Brokers and sympathizers also differ substantially on political variables, both recalled and current, which we examine in detail in subsequent sections. A demographic

¹⁰Respondent consent and data-protection procedures are described in OA Section A.10.

comparison that also includes the reweighted Nuevo León comparison population is reported in OA Section A.7.

Table 1: Sample characteristics: precinct chiefs and party sympathizers

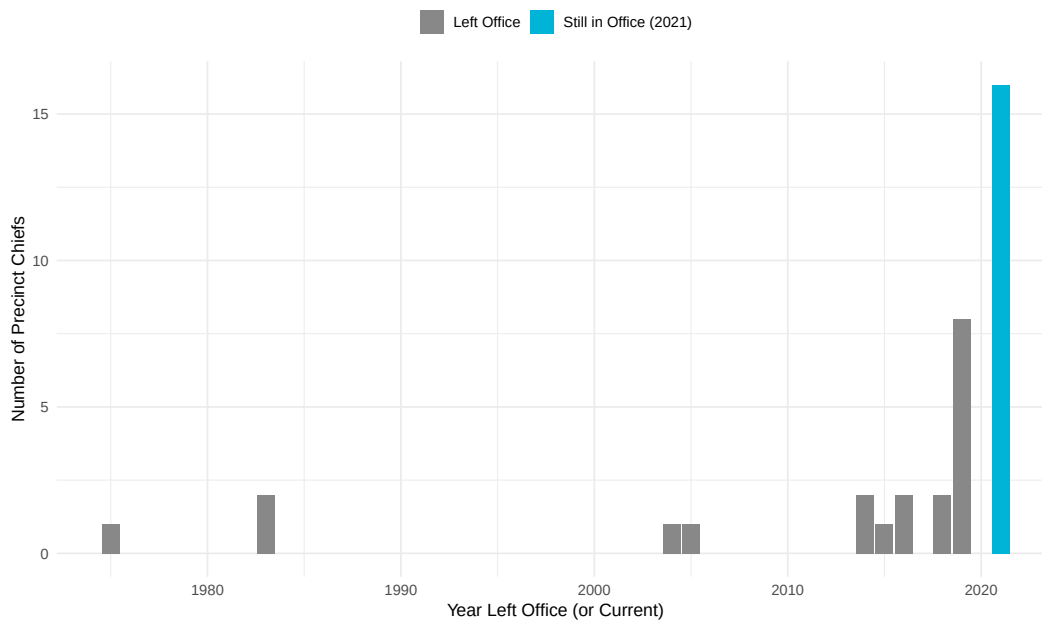
	<i>Precinct Chiefs</i>			<i>Party Sympathizers</i>			
	<i>N</i>	Mean	SD	<i>N</i>	Mean	SD	Diff.
Panel A. Basic Characteristics							
Age	51	67.55	11.93	36	59.08	13.71	8.47***
Female	51	0.69	0.47	37	0.73	0.45	−0.04
Education	51	6.49	2.72	36	7.89	2.07	−1.40***
Income (age 14)	48	0.44	0.50	29	0.52	0.51	−0.08
Subj. Inc. (age 14)	42	5.10	2.40	26	5.12	2.14	−0.02
Panel B. Political Variables							
<i>Pre-broker</i>							
Family Activism	41	0.66	0.48	36	0.28	0.45	0.38***
Political Talk at Home	42	0.26	0.45	37	0.08	0.28	0.18**
Young Ambition	40	0.25	0.44	37	0.05	0.23	0.20**
Family Encouraged	35	0.40	0.50	24	0.46	0.51	−0.06
<i>Current</i>							
Political Interest	51	0.59	0.50	37	0.24	0.43	0.34***
Voted	41	0.95	0.22	37	0.89	0.31	0.06
Party ID	41	0.71	0.46	35	0.26	0.44	0.45***
Ran for Office	40	0.10	0.30	37	0.03	0.16	0.07

Notes: Survey of Precinct Chiefs (Nuevo León, 2021). Entries are group means and standard deviations; *Diff.* is the precinct-chief minus party-sympathizer difference in means. *N* varies across rows because of item nonresponse. *Variable definitions.* *Age:* age in years at the time of the survey. *Female:* = 1 if female. *Education:* respondent’s own education on a 0–10 ordinal scale (0 = no schooling, 3 = primary, 5 = secondary, 7 = preparatoria, 8 = technical career, 9 = bachelor’s, 10 = postgraduate). *Income (age 14):* = 1 if household income at age 14 was similar to or higher than other Nuevo León families at that time. *Subjective Income (age 14):* family income at age 14 placed on a 0–10 ladder. *Family Activism:* = 1 if “most” or “all” family members participate in social or political activism. *Political Talk at Home:* = 1 if politics was discussed at home “always” or “frequently” during childhood. *Young Ambition:* = 1 if the respondent aspired to a political career between ages 15 and 25. *Family Encouraged:* ordinal (−1/0/1) for parental discouragement/indifference/encouragement of political involvement during the respondent’s youth. *Political Interest:* = 1 if the respondent reports “a lot” of current interest in politics. *Voted:* = 1 if the respondent voted in the June 2021 elections. *Party ID:* = 1 if the respondent currently sympathizes with a political party. *Ran for Office:* = 1 if the respondent has run as a candidate for popular election. See OA Section A.5.1 for exact question wording. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

5.2 Brokerage as a durable occupation

Brokerage in our sample is a long-tenure occupation, not an episodic role. Among precinct chiefs with complete service records, average tenure is 22.9 years. Those still active at the time of the survey had served 27 years on average, and even those who had left office averaged nearly 20 years (Figure 2). Many served three or four decades in the same precinct.

Figure 2: Tenure as precinct chief

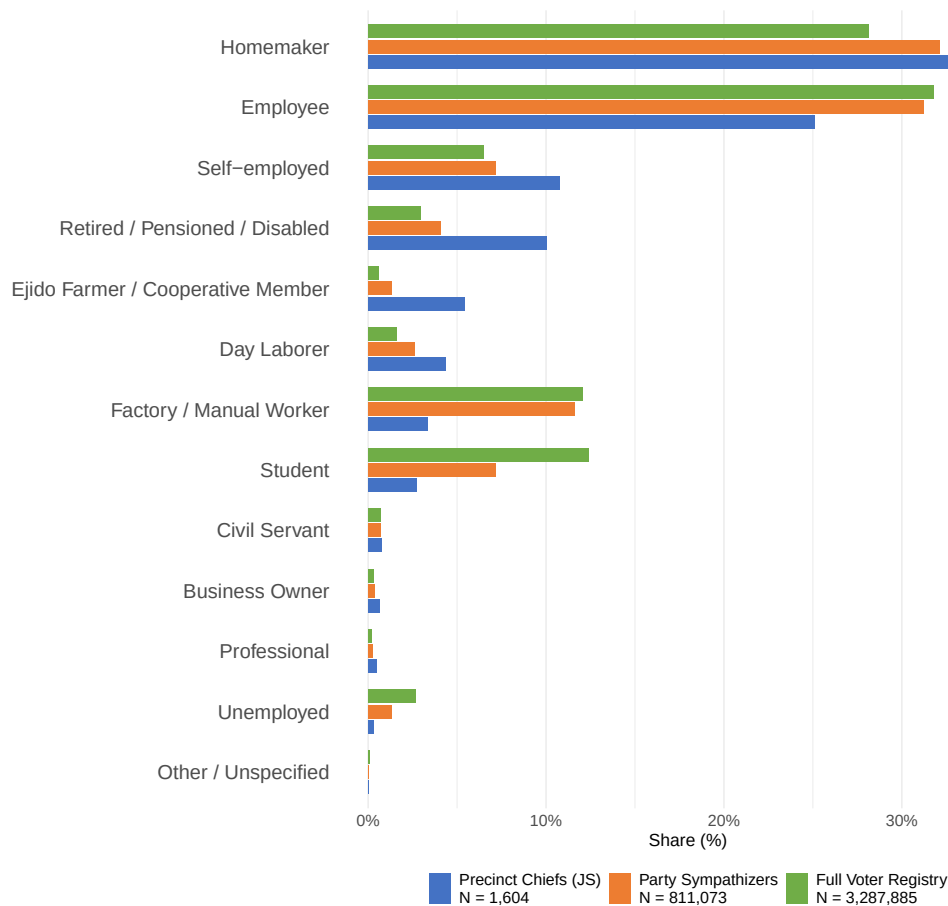


Notes: Survey of Precinct Chiefs 2021. Sample restricted to precinct chiefs with non-missing first and last year of service ($N = 36$). Average tenure: 22.9 years; active at time of survey ($N = 16$): 27 years; left office ($N = 20$): 19.6 years. “Still in Office” denotes respondents who reported being active at time of survey (coded 2021). Tenure = last year – first year.

The occupational profile of precinct chiefs reinforces this picture of brokerage as a durable form of political work. Figure 3 compares three samples: precinct chiefs, party sympathizers, and the full Nuevo León voter registry. Across all three groups, homemakers and employees dominate the occupational distribution. Precinct chiefs, however, are especially overrepresented among homemakers and less concentrated among employees and factory workers than both party sympathizers and the full voter registry. They are also more likely to be self-employed or outside

standard wage employment. Like the other groups, they are rarely represented among white-collar occupations. Although these occupations are recorded in the 2012 voter registry and may not capture employment during brokers' peak years of service, the pattern is consistent with the view that brokerage is a primary occupation rather than a side job.

Figure 3: Employment distribution across samples

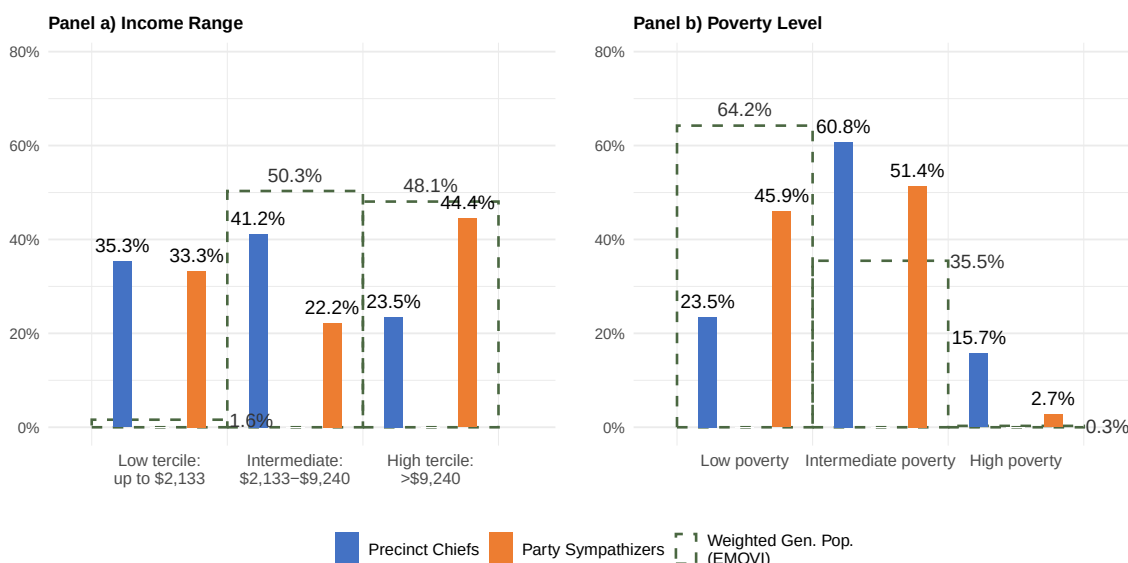


Notes: Share of each employment category within each sample, as recorded in the 2012 voter registry (*Lista Nominal*). Precinct chief administrative roster (Roster 1, $N = 1,604$); party sympathizers matched to the voter registry ($N = 811,073$); full Nuevo León voter registry ($N = 3,287,885$).

At the time of the survey, both PRI sympathizers and brokers were poorer than the Nuevo León comparison population, with brokers exhibiting the lowest income levels of the three groups. Figure 4 compares current socioeconomic status across brokers, sympathizers, and the reweighted Nuevo León comparison population. On current household income, brokers and sympathizers

cluster in the bottom two terciles, well below the comparison population (panel a). The gap is even starker on the poverty index: roughly 16% of brokers fall in the highest-poverty tier, compared with about 3% of sympathizers and less than 1% of the comparison population (panel b).¹¹

Figure 4: Current socioeconomic status



Notes: Survey of Precinct Chiefs 2021 ($N = 53$ brokers, $N = 37$ sympathizers) and EMOVI 2021 ($N = 3,767$, reweighted). Panel (a): monthly household income in pesos, terciled from the combined broker–sympathizer distribution; cutpoints applied to the EMOVI for comparability. Panel (b): poverty index levels. General population reweighted to match broker sample demographics. See OA Section A.6 for index construction.

5.3 Who becomes a broker?

Brokers differ from party sympathizers in recalled early political engagement, but not in childhood economic position. Table 2 reports regression-adjusted differences controlling for age, gender, and education. Brokers are more likely to report higher family activism, more likely to report that politics was frequently discussed at home during childhood, and more likely to report youthful political ambition. By contrast, parental encouragement does not distinguish brokers from sympathizers, and neither objective nor subjective income at age 14 is statistically significant. Brokers, then, do

¹¹The poverty index is a simplified adaptation of the AMAI *Niveles Socioeconómicos* classification. It combines the respondent’s education and the household’s bathrooms, rooms, and cars into a 0–100 score: Low poverty ≥ 65 ; Intermediate poverty 35–64; High poverty < 35 . See OA Section A.6 for construction and cross-survey harmonization with EMOVI 2021.

not appear to come from more advantaged childhood backgrounds. Instead, they grew up in more politically engaged family environments and report greater early political ambition.

Table 2: Selection into brokerage

	(1) Family Activism	(2) Political Talk at Home	(3) Young Ambition	(4) Family Encour- aged	(5) Income	(6) Subjective Income
Precinct Chief	0.364*** (0.119)	0.198** (0.093)	0.234*** (0.088)	0.028 (0.143)	-0.112 (0.135)	0.052 (0.629)
Age	-0.006 (0.004)	-0.002 (0.003)	-0.004 (0.003)	-0.011** (0.005)	0.004 (0.005)	0.021 (0.025)
Female	-0.120 (0.128)	0.194* (0.102)	-0.084 (0.097)	0.054 (0.155)	0.051 (0.141)	0.755 (0.632)
Education	-0.030 (0.026)	-0.006 (0.020)	0.014 (0.019)	-0.012 (0.033)	0.036 (0.025)	0.367*** (0.126)
Observations	75	77	75	58	75	67
R ²	0.17	0.11	0.12	0.09	0.04	0.12
Control Mean	0.294	0.086	0.057	0.435	0.556	5.160

Notes: OLS estimates; the Precinct Chief coefficient is the regression-adjusted broker-sympathizer difference, controlling for age, gender, and education. Control Mean is the party-sympathizer mean. Outcomes: (1) Family Activism, = 1 if “most” or “all” family members are reported to engage in social or political activism; (2) Political Talk at Home (childhood), = 1 if politics was discussed at home “always” or “frequently” during the respondent’s childhood, 0 if “sometimes,” “rarely,” or “never”; (3) Young Ambition, = 1 if the respondent aspired to a political career between ages 15 and 25; (4) Family Encouraged, ordinal (-1/0/1): 1 if either parent encouraged political involvement during the respondent’s youth, 0 if indifferent, -1 if discouraged; (5) Income (age 14), = 1 if household income at age 14 was similar to or higher than other Nuevo León families at that time (0 if lower); (6) Subjective Income (age 14), family income placed on a 0–10 ladder at age 14. See OA Section A.5.1 for the exact question wording. Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Qualitative evidence from an open-ended question asking respondents how they became brokers points to three common paths. First, some respondents describe their appointment as recognition for prior community activism and problem-solving: “[I] liked helping people”; “[I] was good at communicating with people from the community”; and “[I] was selected because I was so active and helped in all kinds of situations.” In these cases, formal appointment appears to recognize de facto community leadership. Second, some respondents describe an internal partisan path, in which they first volunteered or performed lower-level party roles: “[I] distributed leaflets”; “[I]

attended party meetings and was seen as very active”; and “[I] was invited by the party president.” Finally, personal networks also mattered, with respondents describing recruitment through party, family, or neighborhood ties.

These patterns are consistent with [Auyero \(2000\)](#), who shows that brokers often present themselves as precocious activists with histories of family activism. These retrospective accounts should be interpreted with caution: Brokers had occupied these roles for many years by the time of the survey, and their narratives may partly reflect the self-presentation of long-standing political activists. Even with this caveat, the qualitative and quantitative evidence point in the same descriptive direction: brokers narrate entry into brokerage through community reputation and prior activism rather than economic advantage.

5.4 Socioeconomic mobility

5.4.1 General patterns

Here, we examine whether brokers’ long-tenure political work is associated with upward socioeconomic mobility. We compare brokers to party sympathizers and, where possible, to the comparison population described above. We construct six mobility indicators, each coded so that positive values denote improvement: household-head education, children’s education, job status, subjective income, subjective housing quality, and household wealth. Survey wording and operational details for each indicator are in OA Section [A.5.1](#). We first compare brokers and sympathizers in a regression framework. For each mobility outcome in Table [3](#), we regress the outcome on a precinct-chief indicator, controlling for age, gender, and education.¹² The coefficient on the *Precinct Chief* indicator reports the adjusted difference between brokers and sympathizers.

Across a range of educational, occupational, and subjective economic outcomes, precinct chiefs do not show significant gains relative to sympathizers. Only one coefficient is statistically significant: brokers’ household-head education improves by 1.55 levels more than sympathizers’ between

¹²Formally, we estimate $y_i = \alpha + \beta \text{Precinct Chief}_i + \mathbf{X}_i' \boldsymbol{\gamma} + \varepsilon_i$, where Precinct Chief_i equals 1 for precinct chiefs and 0 for party sympathizers, and $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes age, gender, and education.

age 14 and the survey (3, column 1). The remaining five estimates are not distinguishable from zero. Brokers thus experience greater generational educational mobility without parallel gains in subjective income, housing, job status, or asset wealth.

Table 3: Socioeconomic mobility

	(1) Δ HH Education	(2) Children's Education	(3) Δ Job Status	(4) Δ Income	(5) Δ House	(6) Δ Wealth
Precinct Chief	1.549* (0.862)	0.263 (0.712)	0.033 (0.352)	−0.552 (0.714)	−0.069 (0.550)	−0.791 (0.775)
Age	0.046 (0.033)	−0.004 (0.039)	−0.006 (0.014)	0.005 (0.029)	0.022 (0.020)	0.057* (0.029)
Female	0.484 (0.841)	1.151 (0.726)	−0.275 (0.364)	−0.839 (0.767)	−0.192 (0.587)	1.234 (0.811)
Education	0.628*** (0.186)	— —	0.055 (0.082)	−0.036 (0.149)	−0.229** (0.108)	0.007 (0.149)
Observations	54	45	49	61	72	64
R ²	0.22	0.06	0.04	0.03	0.11	0.10
Control Mean	3.042	0.630	0.429	0.400	0.393	1.433

Notes: OLS estimates. All specifications control for age, gender, and education, except column 2 (Children's Education), which omits the education control to avoid mechanical collinearity with the dependent variable (constructed as the difference between children's and respondent's own education on the same scale). Δ HH Education: current household head's education minus the household head's education at age 14. Children's Education: average of the respondent's children's education minus the respondent's own education, restricted to children aged 25 and older (positive values indicate children are more educated than the respondent, i.e., upward intergenerational mobility). Δ Job Status: occupational prestige relative to the father's job at age 14 (−2 to +2). Δ Income: subjective income now vs. at age 14 (0–10 scale). Δ House: subjective housing now vs. at age 14 (0–10 scale). Δ Wealth: difference in asset index (rooms + bathrooms + cars), current vs. age 14. Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Even if average mobility differences are limited, patterns may differ by gender. Female labor-force participation grew substantially during the second half of the twentieth century, meaning that women in our sample entered and navigated the labor market under different conditions than men from the same birth cohorts. Table 4 adds an interaction between the *Precinct Chief* and female indicators. These estimates suggest that female brokers fare worse than male brokers. Male brokers improve their subjective income placement by 1.15 points relative to male sympathizers, while female brokers decline by 1.06 points relative to female sympathizers—a gap of 2.20 points,

or roughly one-fifth of the 0–10 income scale. The pattern is similar for job status and housing mobility: in each case, the estimated effect for female brokers is negative relative to female sympathizers, whereas male brokers remain above their own sympathizer baseline.

Although our data cannot precisely identify the causal effect of entering brokerage, the results raise the possibility that these women would have been better off had they not become brokers. These findings are consistent with recent work showing that the gendered division of political labor gives female brokers fewer opportunities to expand their local networks and, plausibly, their opportunities for career advancement (Daby, 2021).

Table 4: Socioeconomic mobility by gender

	(1) ΔHH Education	(2) Children’s Education	(3) ΔJob Status	(4) ΔIncome	(5) ΔHouse	(6) ΔWealth
Precinct Chief	1.580 (1.487)	0.997 (0.996)	0.904 (0.646)	1.145 (0.835)	1.005** (0.496)	−1.041 (1.217)
Female	0.511 (1.259)	1.825** (0.807)	0.514 (0.642)	0.481 (0.783)	0.734 (0.572)	1.045 (0.982)
Chief × Female	−0.047 (1.721)	−1.048 (1.321)	−1.324* (0.717)	−2.204** (1.078)	−1.407* (0.776)	0.333 (1.452)
Age	0.046 (0.037)	−0.009 (0.034)	−0.005 (0.014)	0.003 (0.027)	0.021 (0.016)	0.058* (0.030)
Education	0.628*** (0.224)	— —	0.069 (0.076)	−0.028 (0.173)	−0.231* (0.136)	0.007 (0.152)
Observations	54	45	49	61	72	64
R ²	0.22	0.07	0.13	0.07	0.12	0.10
Control Mean	3.042	0.630	0.429	0.400	0.393	1.433

Notes: OLS estimates. All specifications control for age, gender, education, and a Precinct Chief × Female interaction, except column 2 (Children’s Education), which omits the education control to avoid mechanical collinearity with the dependent variable (constructed as the difference between children’s and respondent’s own education on the same scale). ΔHH Education: current household head’s education minus the household head’s education at age 14. Children’s Education: average of the respondent’s children’s education minus the respondent’s own education, restricted to children aged 25 and older (positive values indicate children are more educated than the respondent, i.e., upward intergenerational mobility). ΔJob Status: occupational prestige relative to the father’s job at age 14 (−2 to +2). ΔIncome: subjective income now vs. at age 14 (0–10 scale). ΔHouse: subjective housing now vs. at age 14 (0–10 scale). ΔWealth: difference in asset index (rooms + bathrooms + cars), current vs. age 14. Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

5.4.2 Breaking down mobility patterns

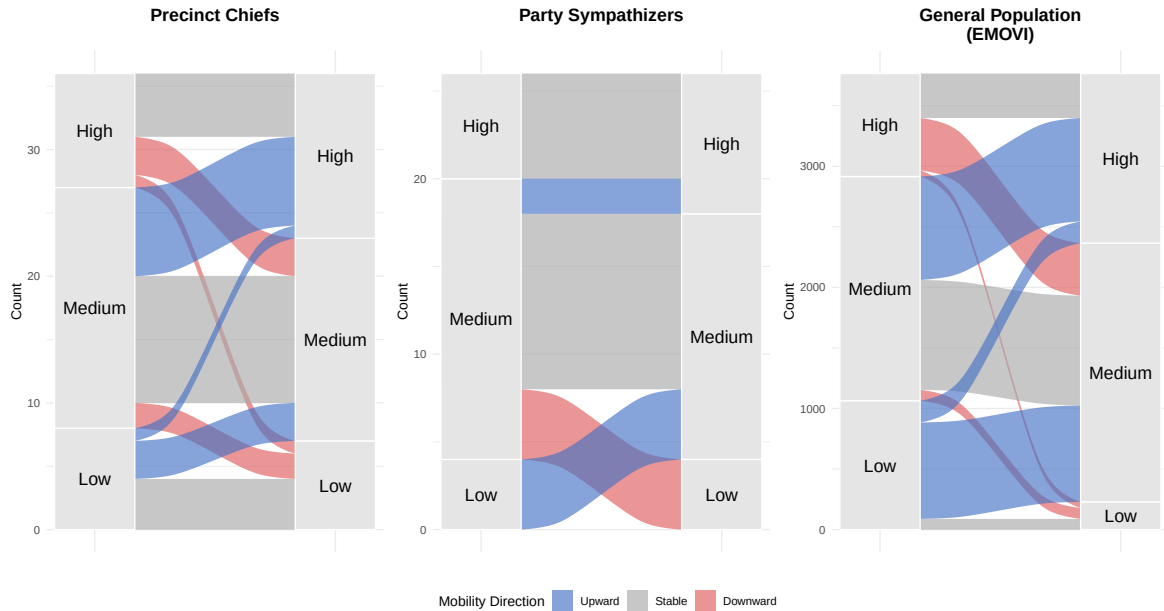
The regression results may mask heterogeneity in mobility patterns. We therefore construct origin–destination (O–D) matrices, shown as flow diagrams, that classify respondents into socioeconomic tiers at age 14 and at the time of the survey.¹³ These analyses do not include controls, and several cells are small, so they should be read as descriptive patterns rather than precise estimates. They nevertheless help separate upward from downward mobility.

Figure 5 traces subjective economic mobility. Respondents placed their family income on a 0–10 ladder relative to other Nuevo León families, once for age 14 and once for the present, with scores of 0–3, 4–6, and 7–10 forming the Low, Medium, and High categories. A respondent who reports 3 at age 14 and 7 today therefore moves from Low to High—not because absolute income increased by a fixed amount, but because their position in the local income distribution improved.

Compared to sympathizers, precinct chiefs exhibit a distinctive mobility pattern. Among those starting from high subjective income, 44% of brokers experienced downward mobility—33% to medium and 11% to low status—while 56% remained at the top. By contrast, all high-origin sympathizers remained in the top category. From the bottom, 50% of low-origin brokers experienced upward mobility (38% to medium and 12% to high). Middle-origin brokers show mixed outcomes, with 37% moving up to high status but 11% falling to low. The reweighted EMOVI panel shows greater upward mobility from both the bottom and middle, as well as more downward mobility from the top, than the sympathizer sample. Brokers’ trajectories therefore resemble the broader population pattern more closely, but with significantly higher persistence at the bottom.

¹³O–D tables are common in classic analyses of social mobility and have also been used to study intragenerational mobility patterns (e.g., Balán et al., 1973).

Figure 5: Economic mobility



Notes: Broker and sympathizer panels: Survey of Precinct Chiefs 2021; respondents placed their family income on a 0–10 ladder relative to all families in Nuevo León, separately for age 14 and the present; terciled into Low (0–3), Medium (4–6), High (7–10); $N = 36$ brokers and 26 sympathizers with both measures non-missing. EMOVI panel: comparable EMOVI 2021 items at age 14 and the present, on a 1–10 ladder relative to all Mexican households; reweighted to the six broker municipalities and the broker roster’s gender composition ($N = 785$ active respondents). Reference population is Mexico-wide for EMOVI versus Nuevo León-specific for the broker survey; see OA Sections A.5.1 and A.9 for details. *Origin–destination percentages* (rows: origin tier; entries: % to Low / Medium / High at destination). Precinct Chiefs: Low $\rightarrow$ 50/38/12; Medium $\rightarrow$ 11/53/37; High $\rightarrow$ 11/33/56. Party Sympathizers: Low $\rightarrow$ 0/100/0; Medium $\rightarrow$ 25/62/12; High $\rightarrow$ 0/0/100. General Population (EMOVI): Low $\rightarrow$ 8/75/17; Medium $\rightarrow$ 5/49/46; High $\rightarrow$ 6/51/43.

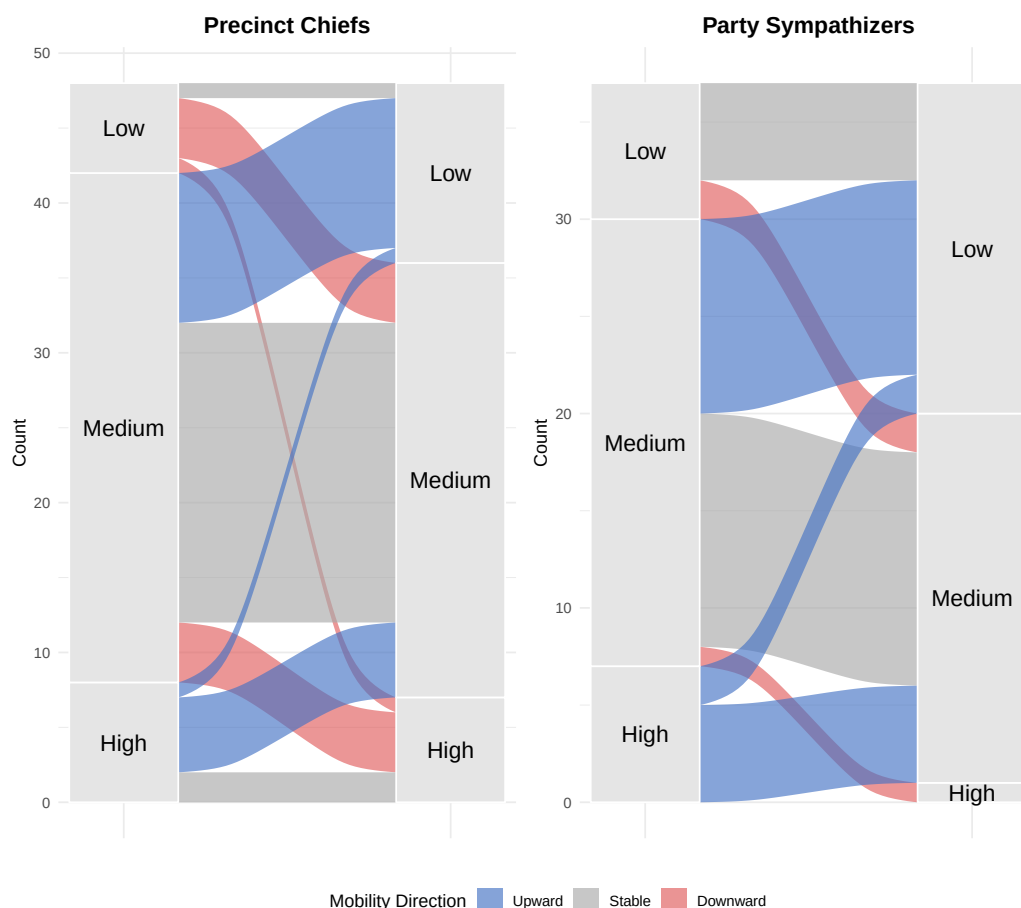
Figure 6 traces mobility on a composite poverty index ranging from 0 to 100, with higher scores indicating lower poverty. The index combines four components: the respondent’s education (40 points), bathrooms (25), rooms (20), and cars (15). Scores below 35 correspond to High poverty, 35–64 to Medium poverty, and 65 or above to Low poverty.¹⁴ The same index is computed for the respondent’s household at age 14, so a respondent who scores below 35 at age 14 and above 65 today moves from High to Low poverty.

The poverty index flows show greater poverty persistence among brokers than among sym-

¹⁴Simplified adaptation of the AMAI *Niveles Socioeconómicos* (NSE) index (Asociación Mexicana de Agencias de Inteligencia de Mercado y Opinión, 2018), the stratification framework widely used in Mexican survey and market research. See OA Section A.6 for the full construction and cross-survey harmonization with EMOVI 2021.

pathizers. Among brokers who start in high poverty, 25% remain there, 62% move to medium poverty, and 12% reach low poverty. By contrast, no high-poverty sympathizers remain in that category, although this comparison is based on small cells. Among medium-origin respondents, 12% of brokers fall into high poverty, compared with 4% of sympathizers.

Figure 6: Poverty mobility



Notes: Precinct Chiefs ($N = 53$) and Party Sympathizers ($N = 37$). Origin (age 14) to destination (current) by poverty index tier: Low (low poverty, ≥ 65); Medium (35–64); High (high poverty, < 35). The same composite index (education 40%, bathrooms 25%, rooms 20%, cars 15%) is applied at both time points; bathroom and car components are binary at both time points to match EMOVI measurement. EMOVI is excluded from the main figure: binary bathroom ownership is near-universal in Nuevo León (approximately 97% at both time points), leaving less than 1% of the weighted sample in the High poverty tier and rendering the EMOVI panel uninformative. See Figure A.2 (Online Appendix) for the EMOVI variant with appropriate caveats, and OA Section A.6 for index construction. *Origin–destination percentages* (rows: origin poverty tier; entries: % to Low / Medium / High poverty at destination). Precinct Chiefs: Low $\rightarrow$ 17/67/17; Medium $\rightarrow$ 29/59/12; High $\rightarrow$ 12/62/25. Party Sympathizers: Low $\rightarrow$ 71/29/0; Medium $\rightarrow$ 44/52/4; High $\rightarrow$ 29/71/0.

Overall, brokers display more polarized trajectories than sympathizers: greater persistence at high-poverty origins (25% vs. 0%), less upward movement from medium origins (29% vs. 44% reaching low poverty), and downward transitions from low-poverty origins that sympathizers do not exhibit (17% vs. 0%). Across both figures, brokers combine upward and downward mobility, whereas sympathizers cluster on stable or improving trajectories. This mixture is consistent with the near-zero average coefficients in Table 3: gains for some brokers and losses for others wash out in the mean. Given the small cell sizes—particularly in the low-origin broker row and the high-origin sympathizer row—these origin–destination percentages should be interpreted as descriptive rather than precise estimates.¹⁵

5.5 Brokers’ political careers

If brokerage does not generate economic returns, it may still serve as a pathway into formal politics. We find little evidence for this view. This section examines brokers’ long-term political engagement and careers: their current political interest, partisan attachment, electoral participation, and broader history of political positions. Brokers report higher levels of current interest in politics than sympathizers, and identify with a political party at more than twice the rate of sympathizers (Table 5). Yet they are no more likely to have voted in the last election or to have run as candidates for elected office; both differences are statistically indistinguishable from zero. Brokerage is therefore associated with stronger political interest and partisan attachment, but not with greater electoral participation or electoral advancement.

¹⁵OA Section A.9.3 reports full-population robustness variants.

Table 5: Political activism and careers

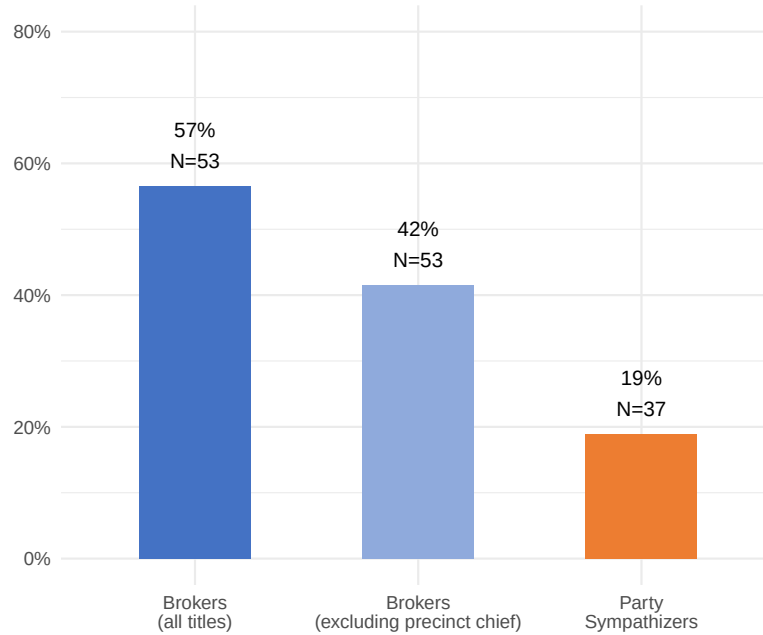
	(1) Political Interest	(2) Voted	(3) Party ID	(4) Ran for Office
Precinct Chief	0.408*** (0.112)	0.098 (0.066)	0.346*** (0.110)	0.047 (0.060)
Age	-0.003 (0.004)	0.001 (0.002)	0.013*** (0.004)	0.001 (0.002)
Female	-0.111 (0.119)	0.015 (0.072)	0.118 (0.119)	-0.163** (0.066)
Education	-0.003 (0.023)	0.032** (0.014)	0.007 (0.023)	0.001 (0.013)
Observations	85	76	74	75
R ²	0.17	0.09	0.29	0.11
Control Mean	0.200	0.886	0.273	0.029

Notes: OLS estimates. All specifications control for age, gender, and education. Political Interest equals 1 if the respondent reports “a lot” of current interest in politics. Voted indicates whether the respondent voted in the June 2021 elections. Party ID equals 1 if the respondent currently sympathizes with a political party. Ran for Office equals 1 if the respondent has run as a candidate for popular election. Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

The survey also asked respondents to list up to five political positions they had held, recording the title, party, start year, and duration of each (OA Section A.5.2). Brokers are far more likely than sympathizers to have held at least one such position: 30 of 53 brokers (57%), or 22 of 53 (42%) once positions that are only *precinct chief* title variants are excluded, compared with 7 of 37 sympathizers (19%) (Figure 7). These positions are roughly evenly split between those that predate the broker appointment and those that follow it, rather than concentrated before appointment.¹⁶ This difference operates on the extensive rather than intensive margin: brokers are more likely than sympathizers to have held any political position, but among position-holders, the average number of positions is similar across groups (2.4 versus 2.1).

¹⁶Among the 44 broker-listed positions for which both the position start year and the broker appointment year are recorded, 17 (39%) predate the appointment, 11 (25%) begin in the same year, and 16 (36%) follow it. An analogous split is not feasible for sympathizers, who have no appointment-year analogue and rarely report position start years.

Figure 7: Share holding any political position



Notes: Survey of Precinct Chiefs 2021 ($N = 53$ brokers, $N = 37$ sympathizers). “All titles” includes any political position listed in survey slots 1–5 (30/53 brokers). “Excl. chief” excludes respondents whose only listed positions were *jefe seccional* title variants (8 brokers); excluding these yields 22/53. See OA Section A.5.2 for the classification of title variants.

All in all, brokers appear to have intense but somewhat marginal political careers. They are more partisan than comparable citizens and more likely to hold organizational roles around the broker position. However, this rarely translates into elected office. Brokerage therefore does not appear to function as a stepping-stone to higher office.

6 Discussion

A natural question is whether the patterns we document reflect the effect of brokerage or selection into brokerage. Our design cannot fully separate these possibilities. Broker status is not randomly assigned, and the measures of early political engagement are retrospective. Still, the evidence helps narrow plausible interpretations. Brokers do not come from more advantaged childhood backgrounds than comparable party sympathizers: neither objective nor subjective income

at age 14 differs systematically across groups. The main observable differences are political, not economic—brokers report greater early political ambition, family activism, and political discussion at home during childhood.

This pattern is difficult to reconcile with a purely economic selection story. If brokers were poorer simply because they originated from more disadvantaged backgrounds, we should observe clear baseline socioeconomic differences relative to politically active non-brokers from the same electoral precincts. We do not. Instead, brokers and sympathizers are similar in childhood socioeconomic status but differ in political ambition and activism. The pattern is therefore likely not fully explained by economic selection alone.

Given its meager economic returns, the puzzle, then, is why brokerage persists as a career. One possibility is that our survey misses some material benefits: small payments, favors, access to services, or benefits for family members. However, brokerage differs from patronage, where political work is secured by a state job tied to the incumbent’s survival (Oliveros, 2021). Precinct chiefs hold no such job. They occupy a more informal and locally embedded position, which makes their long tenure harder to explain through material incentives alone. Brokerage may also generate non-material returns: local status, recognition, proximity to politicians, and an identity built around solving community problems (Auyero, 2001). Brokers may live partly *for* politics even when they do not live well *off* politics.

The organizational structure of brokerage makes the latter interpretation plausible. Brokerage involves investment in highly specific political assets. Because of their embeddedness, brokers accumulate local knowledge, neighborhood networks, party loyalty, and reputations (Auyero, 2001; Szwarcberg, 2015). These assets are valuable inside the party machine, but they may not travel well outside it. They may help brokers remain useful to parties in their communities without translating into formal employment, elected office, or broader economic mobility. In this sense, brokerage may be a stable career built around non-portable capital that locks individuals in a path with limited opportunities for advancement.

7 Conclusion

Drawing on an original life-history survey of former precinct chiefs in Mexico's largest political party, we provided the first systematic evidence on the long-run trajectories of political brokers. We established that political brokerage is a durable occupation rather than a temporary activity. Brokers report average tenures of more than two decades. Yet the people who hold this occupation remain economically marginal. They are poorer than both comparable party sympathizers and the broader population, and brokers show little evidence of greater economic mobility than comparable sympathizers: the mobility regressions reveal few differences across income, housing, job status, and wealth. Brokers are not drawn from economically advantaged backgrounds. Instead, they report substantially higher levels of early political engagement—ambition, family activism, and political discussion at home during childhood—than party sympathizers. Brokerage is strongly associated with partisan identification, but not with higher rates of voting or candidacy for elected office. Women brokers also display a penalty in terms of job status, income, and housing mobility. Brokerage deepens partisan attachment without opening a path to elected office.

These patterns help characterize brokerage as a profession: it has the durability of an occupation—decades of tenure and defined entry pathways—but not its economic returns. Those who make political work their livelihood do not necessarily live well from it. Studying brokerage in the long run yields two contributions. First, it extends the study of political careers beyond formal office. Officeholders are disproportionately drawn from privileged strata ([Carnes and Lupu, 2023](#)); brokers, among the most common political actors in much of the developing world, are not. Class gaps in political representation therefore look different once we look beyond elected office. Second, the paper identifies a durable political workforce that sustains party organization from below ([Langston and Castro Cornejo, 2023](#)) while receiving limited material rewards. In this regard, brokers differ from patronage employees incorporated into the state ([Oliveros, 2021](#)). This is an organizational consequence of relational clientelism that the electoral-mobilization literature, which often treats brokers as fungible operatives, has largely missed.

Although this study is based on a limited sample in a specific Mexican state, the findings may apply to other settings where parties combine territorial organization with sustained access to state resources—the conditions that make relational clientelism viable. Future work should examine whether similar patterns emerge in other settings where strong electoral machines rely on long-term brokers, such as Argentine *punteros*, Indian party *karyakartas*, and Brazilian *cabos eleitorais*.

Our study also has limitations. It focused on a relatively small sample in a single city and relied on retrospective life-history reports. We therefore interpret our findings as descriptive rather than causal. At the same time, our findings show that researchers can generate systematic evidence on a hard-to-reach political population. Combining official party rosters, matched comparison groups, and life-history methods offers a replicable approach for tracing the long-run trajectories of informal political elites.

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Online Appendix

Political Brokerage as a Profession: Evidence from Mexico

A.1 Data Details

A.1.1 Broker Data

We assembled a dataset of *jefes seccionales* (section-level party brokers) in Nuevo León from internal administrative rosters compiled by a major political party. The source files consist of Excel workbooks with one sheet per electoral district and include each broker's federal and local district identifiers, precinct/section identifiers, municipality, full name, and limited administrative information (e.g., address, phone number, and status indicators). After harmonizing variable names and stacking sheets, we constructed a unified broker-level dataset with one observation per roster entry totaling 2,065 unique valid observations.

A.1.1.1 Data Linkage to the Voter Registry

To obtain demographic characteristics for brokers, we linked the roster to the voter registry (Lista Nominal, LN) for Nuevo León. The LN contains administrative information recorded on voter identification cards, including sex, date of birth, municipality, and a broad employment category for almost 3.3 million voters in the state in 2012. Access to the LN was restricted: the registry was not provided as a freely shareable dataset. Instead, we were authorized to perform record linkage and extract non-identifying demographic variables for matched individuals. Following linkage, we were also provided with the same basic aggregate demographics for the full LN as well as for the subset of voters matched to the *jefes seccionales* data. All other data provided was aggregated; no other PII was shared. No other data from the LN remains in any of the research servers and is not included in the replication archive.

Because the broker roster does not contain a unique voter registry identifier, linkage was conducted using names and geographic information. We implemented a blocked matching procedure in which broker and LN records were first restricted to common municipality and federal electoral district cells. Within each geographic block, we performed approximate string matching between broker full names and concatenated LN names using Jaro–Winkler distance. For each broker, we retained the closest candidate match within the relevant block.

To minimize false positives, we employed a conservative validation strategy. Exact string matches were automatically accepted. For non-exact matches, we examined multiple string-distance diagnostics and applied a similarity threshold calibrated through visual inspection ($JW < 0.052$). Candidate matches above the threshold were manually reviewed using consistent criteria (e.g., agreement in surnames, plausibility of typographical variation, and rejection of clearly distinct individuals). Only exact matches, high-similarity automated matches, and manually validated matches were retained as valid links. For all other cases, LN demographic fields were set to missing rather than assigning uncertain matches. Using this procedure, we obtained valid voter-registry matches for approximately 78% of broker records ($N = 1,604$ out of 2,065).

A.1.1.2 Construction of the Analysis Dataset

The final linked dataset combines broker administrative variables (e.g., district, section, municipality, and roster status indicators) with voter-registry demographics for validated matches. We retain only a minimal set of registry variables necessary for descriptive analysis, including sex, date of birth, municipality, and employment category. This approach incorporates administrative demographics where linkage confidence is high while preserving a conservative treatment of unmatched observations.

A.1.1.3 Gender Imputation for Unmatched Cases

A subset of brokers could not be confidently linked to voter-registry records and therefore lack administrative gender information. To avoid systematic loss of observations in descriptive analyses,

we impute gender using a name-based procedure tailored to Spanish naming conventions. We first extract a first given name from the broker’s full name string using standardized rules that account for initials, compound names, and common religious prefixes (e.g., “San” or “Santa”). We then apply an AI-assisted and manually verified dictionary of Mexican first names to assign a gender category.

Voter-registry gender is treated as the authoritative measure whenever available. Name-based imputation is used only when registry gender is missing. Ambiguous tokens, non-name entries, or cases without a clearly identifiable first name are left as missing rather than force-classified.

A.1.1.4 Anonymization and Data Security

Given the sensitive nature of the rosters and the registry linkage, all personally identifying information (PII) was anonymized prior to analysis and replication. Specifically, names, addresses, phone numbers, registry identifiers, and internal unique identifiers were replaced with randomly generated alphanumeric codes. The anonymization routine produces (i) an anonymized analysis dataset and (ii) a separate key file mapping original values to anonymized codes. The key file is stored securely and is not publicly released.

To comply with data access restrictions and protect confidentiality, the raw voter registry file was not retained after linkage. Only the anonymized linked dataset and a minimal anonymized extract of registry demographics are preserved for analysis. Consequently, the publicly shared replication materials contain no personally identifying information and do not permit reconstruction of the original registry records.

A.1.1.5 Estimating Age and Sex-Weighted Descriptive Statistics

To ensure that descriptive statistics on brokers are not driven by differential linkage rates or demographic composition in the matched sample, we report age- and sex-weighted descriptives using information from the voter registry (Lista Nominal, LN). Because the LN contains administrative demographic fields for the universe of registered voters in Nuevo León in 2012, it provides a

natural benchmark for the age and sex distribution of the relevant political population.

Consistent with the data access protocol described in the linkage section, we did not retain or directly analyze the full individual-level LN file. Instead, following linkage in a restricted environment, we were provided with anonymized demographic extracts and aggregate age and sex distributions for (i) the full LN and (ii) the subset of registry records successfully matched to the broker roster. These extracts contained only non-identifying variables (age, sex, and broad geographic identifiers).

We construct post-stratification weights based on joint age and sex cells. Individuals are grouped into mutually exclusive five-year age categories and sex, and we compute the share of each age–sex cell in the LN benchmark distribution. We then calculate the corresponding cell shares in the analytic sample of brokers with validated registry matches. Weights are defined as the ratio of the LN population share to the sample share within each age–sex cell. Unmatched observations are retained in unweighted descriptive summaries.

A.1.2 Voter Registry Data

The voter registry (Lista Nominal, LN) in Mexico is an administrative database maintained by the national electoral authority and provided to legally registered political parties for electoral purposes. The registry contains near-universal coverage of registered voters and includes individual-level administrative information recorded on voter identification cards. For this project, we worked with LN data corresponding to the 2012 registry for the state of Nuevo León, which contains approximately 3.3 million registered voters. Due to legal and confidentiality restrictions, the full individual-level registry cannot be freely shared or distributed outside authorized environments. Consistent with these restrictions, we were granted controlled access to the LN solely for the purposes of record linkage and the extraction of non-identifying demographic variables in a secure server environment.

A.1.3 Party Sympathizer Data

Roster 2 consists of all citizens who attended party rallies and were recorded in the party’s internal rally-attendance logs. These individuals are identified in our data by a binary indicator (`inprilist = 1`) appended to their voter registry record (Roster 2; $N \approx 800,000$). Because these individuals are already present in the Lista Nominal with a unique voter registry code (*clave de elector*), the match to demographic variables is exact, yielding a 100% merge rate to registry demographics. This stands in contrast to the broker roster, which lacked a registry identifier and required probabilistic name-matching (see above).

A.2 Sampling Strategy and Construction of the Comparison Group

A.2.1 Broker Sample (Roster 1)

Because the administrative records were more than two decades old, reaching listed individuals required a flexible sampling strategy. We consolidated all available contact information from Roster 1, removed duplicates, and identified 2,065 unique brokers. Using a fixed random seed, we generated a single random ordering of the full roster and assigned cases sequentially to nine interviewers across three survey waves, ensuring equal selection probability for all listed brokers.

A.2.2 Post-Hoc Matched Sampling for the Comparison Group

Ideally, we would have drawn a random pre-specified sample of sympathizers matched to brokers on demographics, political history, and location. In practice, two constraints precluded this approach.

Data limitations. The information available for Roster 2 is limited to age, gender, and last registered address—the same fields available for brokers—and the list had not been systematically

updated since 2015. This constrained the variables available for pre-matching.

Logistical constraints. A preliminary check on the Roster 2 phone numbers indicated that approximately 49% were valid (i.e., not disconnected). Foreseeing that the total number of completed broker interviews would be small, constructing a pre-specified comparison group by random sampling from the full sympathizer roster would have produced a large, heterogeneous control group relative to the tiny and geographically concentrated treatment group—substantially increasing variance in potential outcomes and reducing statistical power.

The extremely low response rate among brokers confirmed this concern. We therefore adopted a *post-hoc matched sampling design*. After completing all broker interviews, we identified the electoral precincts and gender distribution of responding brokers. We then sampled comparison individuals from Roster 2 who matched these precinct-by-gender combinations. We did not match on age, as doing so would have reduced the eligible pool of controls substantially and rendered the design infeasible given the anticipated rate of invalid phone numbers.

The resulting comparison candidate pool comprised 5,562 individuals. Of these, 3,906 (70%) had a listed phone number; of those, 1,674 ultimately had a valid, reachable number. While this adaptive design departs from pre-specified independent sampling, it represents a deliberate trade-off: by drawing controls from the same precincts as responding brokers, we minimize the risk that outcome differences reflect differences in local context rather than broker status. Individuals in both rosters can be understood as members of a single population of party-connected citizens—the key difference being that some were selected into formal broker roles and others were not (Figure 1 in main text).

We acknowledge that response patterns may be correlated with unobserved characteristics related to mobility outcomes. By sampling controls from the same geographic units as responding brokers, we mitigate concern about local context confounds, but selection on unobservables within geographic units cannot be ruled out. This constraint motivates our use of a second, independent comparison group based on the representative population survey described in Section 3 of the main text.

A.3 Survey Team and Training

The telephone survey was conducted by nine undergraduate students from Tecnológico de Monterrey, Monterrey. Enumerators received a two-day training covering survey administration, respondent engagement, and data security protocols. Each enumerator was provided with a project-specific SIM card that was deactivated upon survey completion.

One field supervisor monitored implementation through daily check-ins and review of call logs. Enumerators were required to submit daily progress reports documenting: (i) number of calls attempted, (ii) successful contacts, (iii) completed interviews, and (iv) appointment scheduling for callbacks.

A.4 Survey Logistics and Field Protocols

Each enumerator received lists of 50 names with contact information. The protocol required: (i) verifying phone numbers and respondent identity; (ii) scheduling interview appointments when contact was established; (iii) searching social media for alternative contact methods when primary numbers failed; (iv) maintaining detailed logs of all contact attempts with date and time stamps.

Enumerators were instructed to accommodate immediate interview requests when appointments were not feasible, requiring them to have the Qualtrics offline application ready and their tracking registry open. Contact information for principal investigators was provided to enumerators for cases requiring additional respondent verification.

A.5 Survey Question Wording

This section reproduces the question wording for all variables used in the analysis, drawn from the survey instrument administered to precinct chiefs and party sympathizers. Questions are presented in English translation with the original Spanish wording in brackets. Subsection [A.5.1](#) covers the variables used in Tables 1–5 (sample characteristics, selection, political careers, and socioeco-

conomic mobility). Subsection [A.5.2](#) documents the classification of political position titles used in Figure 7. Operational variable codes and cross-survey harmonization for the poverty index are in Section [A.6](#).

A.5.1 Outcome Variables

Tables [1–5](#) use the variables described below. All variables are constructed from the broker phone survey. We translate each survey question from the original Spanish instrument; the original wording appears in brackets. Unless noted otherwise, “don’t know” and “no answer” responses are coded as missing.

Treatment indicator. Equals 1 if the respondent is a precinct chief (from Roster 1), 0 if a party sympathizer (from Roster 2).

Control variables (all tables). *Age*: 2021 minus year of birth, entered as continuous. *Female*: equals 1 if respondent is female, 0 if male. *Education*: ordinal scale (0–10) coding the respondent’s own educational attainment: 0 = no schooling, 2 = primary incomplete, 3 = primary complete, 4 = secondary incomplete, 5 = secondary complete, 6 = preparatoria incomplete, 7 = preparatoria complete (including technical preparatoria and *normal*), 8 = bachelor’s incomplete or technical career, 9 = bachelor’s complete, 10 = postgraduate. Adult-respondent answers in this survey realize values {0, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10}; the omitted code (1) corresponds to preschool, which does not appear as an adult educational attainment.

Table 2: Selection into Brokerage

The first four columns capture the respondent’s recalled family political environment and political socialization; the last two capture childhood economic position. The Family Activism question is fielded inside the “Personal Political History” module, between recall items on the age at which one’s interest in politics began and the parent or relative who introduced the respondent to politics,

so respondents answer in the context of their family of origin even though the Spanish wording uses present tense.

1. **Family Activism.** Binary. “How many members of your family would you say participate in social or political activism?” [Orig.: *¿Cuántos miembros de su familia diría que participan en activismo social o político?*] Response options: all, most, some, few, none. Coded 1 if “most” or “all,” 0 otherwise.
2. **Political Talk at Home (childhood).** Binary. “Would you say that during your childhood politics was discussed at home. . .” [Orig.: *Usted diría que durante su infancia se platicaba de política en casa. . .*] Response options: always, frequently, sometimes, rarely, never. Coded 1 if “always” or “frequently,” 0 if “sometimes,” “rarely,” or “never.”
3. **Young Ambition.** Binary. “Thinking about your youth, between ages 15 and 25: did you aspire to have a career in politics?” [Orig.: *Pensando en su juventud, digamos cuando tenía entre 15 y 25 años: ¿usted aspiraba a tener una carrera en la política?*] Coded 1 if yes, 0 if no.
4. **Family Encouraged.** Ordinal (–1, 0, 1). Constructed from two items asking separately about the respondent’s father and mother: “Did [your father/mother] encourage you to get involved in politics, was he/she indifferent, or did he/she prefer that you not get involved?” [Orig.: *¿Lo animaba a involucrarse en la política, le daba igual, o prefería que no se involucrara?*] Coded 1 if either parent encouraged involvement, 0 if indifferent, –1 if either parent discouraged involvement.
5. **Income (age 14).** Binary. “Thinking about your family’s income when you were 14, compared to other Nuevo León families at that time, would you say your household’s income was much lower than the average, lower, similar to the average, higher, or much higher than the average?” [Orig.: *Pensando en su ingreso familiar de cuando tenía 14 años, en comparación con otras familias Neolonesas de entonces, diría que el ingreso de su hogar era: muy inferior al promedio, inferior, similar al promedio, superior, o muy superior al promedio?*] Coded 0 if “much lower” or “lower” (*muy inferior* or *inferior*), 1 if “similar,” “higher,” or “much higher.”

6. **Subjective Income (age 14).** Continuous (0–10). “Using a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 represents families with the lowest incomes and 10 those with the highest, where would you place your family’s income at that time?” [Orig.: *Usando una escala de 0 a 10, en la que 0 son las familias con los ingresos más bajos y 10 las más altos, ¿dónde pondría su ingreso familiar de aquél entonces?*]

Tables 3 and 4: Socioeconomic Mobility

All six outcomes measure intragenerational change between age 14 and the time of the survey. Positive values indicate improvement.

1. **Δ HH Education.** Difference in the ordinal education level (0–10 scale) of the current household head minus the household head at age 14. The scale runs from 0 (no schooling) to 10 (postgraduate). Survey question for each period: “What was the last grade of schooling that [the head of household] completed?” [Orig.: *¿Cuál fue el último año de estudios que [el/la jefe de hogar] aprobó en la escuela?*]
2. **Children’s Education.** Average of the respondent’s children’s education minus the respondent’s own education, on the same 0–10 ordinal scale used for Δ HH Education. The average is restricted to children aged 25 and older. The survey question (“What was the last grade of schooling reached?” [Orig.: *¿Cuál fue el último grado de escolaridad alcanzado?*]) records current rather than eventual attainment, so children still in school enter as if their schooling were complete. Because sympathizers’ children are markedly younger than brokers’ (44% under 25 vs. 7%), including them biases the metric asymmetrically; restricting to children aged 25 and older removes the bulk of in-school censoring. Positive values indicate that children are, on average, more educated than the respondent (upward intergenerational mobility).
3. **Δ Job Status.** “If you compare the prestige of your job with the main job your father had during your childhood, would you say the prestige of your current job is...” [Orig.: *Si compara el prestigio de su trabajo con el principal trabajo que su padre tenía durante su infancia, diría*

que el prestigio de su trabajo actual es...] Five-point scale recoded to: −2 (much lower than father), −1 (lower), 0 (equal), 1 (higher), 2 (much higher).

4. **ΔIncome.** Difference in subjective income placement (0–10 scale) between current and age 14. Both items ask: “Using a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 represents families with the lowest incomes and 10 those with the highest, where would you place your family’s income [now/at that time]?”
5. **ΔHouse.** Difference in subjective housing placement (0–10 scale) between current and age 14. Both items ask: “Using a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 represents the poorest households and 10 the wealthiest, where would you place your household [now/at that time]?”
6. **ΔWealth.** Difference in an asset index (current minus age 14). The index sums three household items: rooms used for sleeping [Orig.: *cuartos que se usaban para dormir, sin contar pasillos ni baños*], bathrooms with shower and toilet [Orig.: *baños completos con regadera y W.C.*], and cars or trucks [Orig.: *automóviles o camionetas*]. Respondents reporting “don’t know” receive 0 for that component.

Table 4 adds an interaction between the treatment indicator and the female dummy to capture gendered heterogeneity. HC1 robust standard errors are used.

Table 5: Political Activism and Careers

1. **Political Interest.** Binary. “How much interest would you say you have in politics currently—a lot, some, a little, or none?” [Orig.: *¿Qué tanto interés diría usted que tiene en la política actualmente? ¿Mucho, algo, poco o nada?*] Coded 1 if “a lot” (*mucho*), 0 otherwise.
2. **Voted.** Binary. “Did you vote or not vote in last June 2021’s elections?” [Orig.: *¿Usted votó o no votó en las elecciones de este pasado junio del 2021?*] Coded 1 if voted, 0 if did not vote.
3. **Party ID.** Binary. “Regardless of which party you supported in the last elections, do you currently sympathize with any political party?” [Orig.: *Independientemente de a qué partido*

apoyó en las últimas elecciones, ¿en este momento simpatiza usted con algún partido político?]

Coded 1 if yes, 0 if no or no answer.

4. **Ran for Office.** Binary. “Have you ever run as a candidate for any elected office?” [Orig.: *¿Alguna vez se ha lanzado como candidato a algún puesto de elección popular?*] Coded 1 if yes (once or more than once), 0 if never.

A.5.2 Political Position Variables

The survey asked respondents to list up to five political positions they have held, recording the title, party affiliation, start year, and duration for each. Brokers and sympathizers received parallel question batteries (*polpositionTX* and *polpositionCTRL*, respectively). Position titles were recorded as free-text entries by enumerators.

Because the survey targeted precinct chiefs, many brokers listed variants of the *jefe seccional* title itself (e.g., “jefe seccional,” “jefa seccional,” “presidenta seccional,” “seccional,” “representante seccional”). To avoid conflating the treatment definition with the outcome, we construct two measures:

1. **Any political position (all titles).** Binary. Equals 1 if the respondent listed at least one political position of any kind across the five slots. Among brokers, 30 of 53 (57%) report at least one position; among sympathizers, 7 of 37 (19%).
2. **Any political position (excluding *jefe seccional*).** Binary. Equals 1 if the respondent listed at least one position whose title is not a variant of *jefe seccional*. Eight brokers listed only *jefe seccional* variants and no other positions; excluding them yields 22 of 53 (42%). This measure captures political experience beyond the broker role itself. No sympathizers held *jefe seccional* titles, so the two measures are identical for the control group.

Titles classified as *jefe seccional* variants include: *jefe seccional*, *jefa seccional*, *presidenta seccional*, *presidente seccional*, *representante seccional*, *seccional*, and *auxiliar seccional*. All

other titles—including *juez auxiliar*, *gestora social*, *coordinador*, *delegada municipal*, *brigadista*, *candidato a alcalde*, and various party committee roles—are retained in the “excluding jefe” measure.

A.6 Socioeconomic Index: Construction and Adaptations

A.6.1 Why a Simplified Asset Index Rather Than Income

Measuring socioeconomic status for political brokers presents a specific challenge: income is the natural benchmark, but it is notoriously difficult to elicit reliably from this population. Brokers occupy informal, hybrid roles — they are party volunteers with no official salary, yet many receive sporadic payments in cash, favors, or access to government programs. These flows are irregular, partly in-kind, and socially sensitive to report. Standard income questions therefore tend to produce severe under-reporting, high rates of refusal, and responses that reflect only formal income streams. In pilot discussions, we found that income questions generated discomfort and defensive responses in a way that asset-based questions did not.

For these reasons, we follow a well-established practice in applied survey research in Mexico and adopt a simplified asset-based index rather than a direct income measure. Asset stocks — education, housing quality, durable goods — are less susceptible to recall error and social desirability bias, and they capture longer-run socioeconomic standing better than current income snapshots for a population whose earnings are volatile and informal.

A.6.2 The AMAI NSE Index as Reference Framework

We use as our reference the *Índice de Nivel Socioeconómico* (NSE) published by the Asociación Mexicana de Agencias de Inteligencia de Mercado y Opinión (AMAI) ([Asociación Mexicana de Agencias de Inteligencia de Mercado y Opinión, 2018](#)). The AMAI NSE is widely used in Mexican survey research and commercial market research to classify households into socioeconomic strata

(A/B through E). It has the advantage of being validated on representative Mexican samples, well-documented, and easily replicable from standard household survey items.

The full AMAI algorithm uses 13 variables scored on a 0–100 point scale and weighted via discriminant analysis. We implement a simplified four-variable version using the subset of items available in both the broker survey and EMOVI 2021, preserving the AMAI weighting structure:

Component	Max. points	AMAI weight
Education	40	highest
Bathrooms	25	
Number of rooms	20	
Cars	15	
Total	100	

Thresholds for the three poverty categories are fixed at equal thirds of the theoretical range: High poverty (Pobreza Alta) < 35 points; Intermediate poverty (Pobreza Media) 35–64 points; Low poverty (Pobreza Baja) ≥ 65 points. These thresholds are applied identically to all three groups (brokers, sympathizers, and EMOVI) to ensure comparability.

A.6.3 Adaptations to the Standard AMAI Algorithm

We make three deliberate departures from the standard AMAI protocol, each documented and justified below.

1. Education: respondent’s own education, not the household head’s. The standard AMAI NSE questionnaire asks about the education of the *jefe o jefa de hogar* (household head), because the index is designed to characterize *household-level* socioeconomic status for market segmentation purposes. In that context, if a well-educated adult child is the household head, the household correctly receives a higher score.

Our purpose is different: we use the index to characterize the *individual broker's* socioeconomic position and compare it across groups. For this purpose, the relevant education variable is the respondent's own. This distinction matters for our sample: 36% of broker respondents and 38% of sympathizer respondents report that someone else — in most cases an adult child — is the current household head. Mechanically applying the AMAI formula would assign these respondents the adult child's (typically higher) education, making the index reflect intergenerational household composition rather than the respondent's own attainment. For 64% of respondents who are themselves the household head, both approaches yield the same result.

We therefore substitute the respondent's own educational attainment for the household head's education. We flag this as a deliberate adaptation: the resulting index measures individual-level socioeconomic position rather than household-level classification, and should be interpreted accordingly.

2. Bathrooms: binary scoring to match EMOVI measurement. The standard AMAI algorithm distinguishes among multiple bathroom counts (0, 1, 2, 3+). The EMOVI survey, however, asks only a binary question at both time points: whether the household had a bathroom inside the dwelling (yes/no at age 14; yes/no currently). To make the two datasets measurement-equivalent, we recode the broker survey's bathroom count to a binary: 0 bathrooms = 5 points, 1 or more bathrooms = 25 points. This harmonization is necessary to avoid comparing two different measurement instruments.

A consequence of this harmonization, documented in the main text, is that approximately 97% of EMOVI respondents in Nuevo León — a high-income, highly urbanized state — report having at least one bathroom. This produces near-zero variation in the High poverty category for EMOVI and limits its utility as a comparison benchmark for poverty mobility (Figure 6). The EMOVI comparison is therefore presented as a supplementary figure (Figure A.2) with appropriate caveats.

3. Cars: binary from count. The AMAI algorithm scores car ownership in tiers (0, 1, 2, 3+). The EMOVI survey records car ownership as a binary variable. We recode broker survey car counts

to a binary consistent with EMOVI measurement.

A.6.4 Operational Variable Codes and Cross-Survey Mapping

Broker Survey Variables. The scoring for each component is as follows. Education (`jefe_edu14`) = the household head’s education when the respondent was 14; for current conditions, the respondent’s own education, per Adaptation 1 above—not the household head’s): no schooling or primary → 5 pts; secondary or technical → 15 pts; preparatoria or bachillerato → 30 pts; university or postgraduate → 40 pts. Number of bathrooms (`banios_14`; `banios`), binary after the recoding described above: 0 → 5 pts; 1 or more → 25 pts. Number of rooms (`cuartos_14`; `cuartos`): 1–2 → 5 pts; 3 → 10 pts; 4 or more → 20 pts. Number of cars (`carros_14`; `carro`), binary after the recoding described above: 0 → 0 pts; 1 or more → 15 pts. Respondents reporting “don’t know / no answer” for any component receive 0 points for that component; cases with all components missing are coded as missing overall.

EMOVI 2021 Variables. The EMOVI 2021 applies the same index logic, using variables: respondent’s own education (`p10`) for current conditions and father’s education (`p36a`) for age-14 conditions; number of rooms (`p112` current; `p21` at age 14); presence of an indoor bathroom (`p115c` current; `p23c` at age 14); car ownership (`p119` current; `p26e` at age 14). Bathroom and car components are binary in both periods of EMOVI by survey design (as well as in our recoded broker variables), preserving cross-survey comparability.

General Population Weights. Main-text comparisons use `factor_broker_pop`, a custom post-stratification weight that restricts the EMOVI sample to the six municipalities covered by the broker survey and re-calibrates the gender distribution to the full *jefes seccionales* administrative roster (34% male). The construction of this weight, the corrections it incorporates relative to earlier versions, and the alternative `factor_emovi` (original EMOVI design weight) are described in detail in Section [A.9](#).

A.7 Descriptive Statistics

Table A.1 presents demographic characteristics of the final sample. Brokers averaged 67.5 years of age (SD = 11.9), with 31.4% male. The comparison group of sympathizers showed similar distributions after matching on electoral section and gender. The Nuevo León representative survey respondents were younger on average (41.9 years) and more gender-balanced (50.1% male).

Table A.1: Sample characteristics by group

	Precinct Chiefs (Roster 1, surveyed)	Party Sympathizers (Roster 2, surveyed)	General Pop. (EMOVI 2021)
<i>N</i>	53	37	3,767
Age, mean (SD)	67.5 (11.9)	59.1 (13.7)	41.9 (11.6)
Female, %	68.6	73.0	49.9
Education, years (mean)	11.2	13.6	10.7
In six broker municipalities, %	100.0	100.0	51.5

Notes: Survey of Precinct Chiefs 2021 (BR, CTR columns) and EMOVI 2021 (Nuevo León adults aged 25–64; EMOVI column). *N* reports the total surveyed sample in each group; individual-row statistics are computed on the non-missing subset (BR: 2 respondents have missing age and 0–2 have missing values on other measures; CTR: 1 respondent has missing age). EMOVI statistics computed using the original survey design weight (`factor`). Education in completed years of schooling. “In six broker municipalities” is 100% by construction for BR and CTR (post-hoc matched sampling); for EMOVI it is the weighted share residing in Monterrey, Guadalupe, San Nicolás de los Garza, Santa Catarina, Apodaca, or San Pedro Garza García.

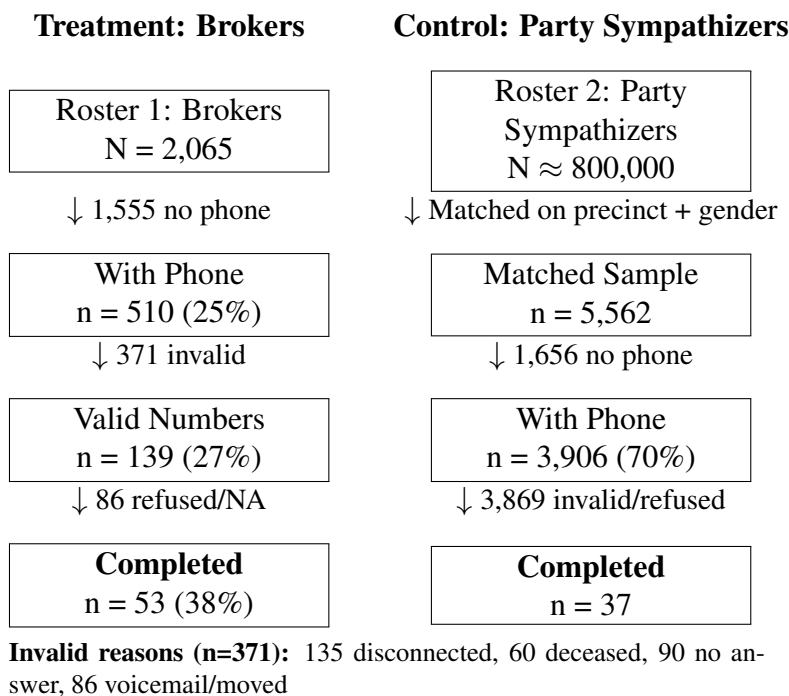
A.8 Response Rates and Sample Attrition

Implementation faced substantial challenges due to the age of administrative records. Of 2,065 unique brokers in Roster 1, only 510 (24%) had listed phone numbers. Among these, 135 were disconnected, 60 individuals were deceased, 90 did not answer after multiple attempts, and over

200 had invalid numbers or permanent voicemail. This yielded approximately 139 valid contacts, of which 53 completed interviews (38% response rate among valid numbers; 2.6% of total sample).

Figure A.1 presents the complete sampling flow from initial rosters to the final analytical sample.

Figure A.1: Sampling flow from administrative records to final sample



The sympathizer roster (Roster 2) presented similar challenges, with approximately 49% valid phone numbers after initial screening. The matched sampling approach yielded 3,906 numbers from 5,562 sampled individuals, with 37 completing interviews. These response rates, while low, are consistent with telephone surveys using decades-old administrative data.

A.9 EMOVI Comparison Population: Weighting Strategy and Cross-Cohort Validity

This section documents the weighting strategy used to construct the EMOVI general-population comparison and evaluates the key methodological assumption underlying cross-cohort compar-

isons.

A.9.1 EMOVI Sampling Weights

The EMOVI 2021 (Encuesta ESRU de Movilidad Social en Nuevo León) survey covers $N = 3,767$ adults aged 25–64 residing in Nuevo León. The data include two weight variables:

1. **factor_emovi (original design weight)**. The Horvitz-Thompson expansion factor provided by ESRU-EMOVI, adjusted via post-stratification on age, sex, education, and occupation to match population benchmarks from the 2020 Censo de Población y Vivienda ([Centro de Estudios Espinosa Yglesias, 2021](#)). This weight produces population-level estimates for the full NL adult population aged 25–64 and is the weight described in the EMOVI methodology document.
2. **factor_broker_pop (broker-population-calibrated weight)**. A custom post-stratification weight that restricts the EMOVI comparison to the six municipalities covered by the broker survey and re-calibrates the gender distribution to match the full *jefes seccionales* (JS) administrative roster. Specifically:
 - *Municipality restriction*: Only EMOVI respondents residing in the six broker survey municipalities are assigned non-negligible weight (INEGI Nuevo León codes: 039 = Monterrey, 026 = Guadalupe, 045 = San Nicolás de los Garza, 047 = Santa Catarina, 006 = Apodaca, 019 = San Pedro Garza García). Respondents in all other municipalities receive a near-zero weight (≈ 0) and are effectively excluded.
 - *Gender calibration*: The gender distribution of the EMOVI subsample is re-weighted to match that of the *full* JS administrative roster in those six municipalities (490 male / 951 female = 34% male), rather than the broker survey respondent sample (27% male). The respondent-sample gender composition reflects non-random response patterns and is therefore an imperfect target; the full roster provides the actual gender distribution of the broker population.

- *Normalization*: The adjusted weights are rescaled so they sum to the full EMOVI sample size ($N = 3,767$), preserving interpretability of weighted counts.

Figures in the main text use `factor_broker_pop` for EMOVI comparisons. Full-NL figures using `factor_emovi` (unfiltered) are reported in the supplementary appendix figures as a robustness check.

A.9.2 Cross-Cohort Comparability: Age Mismatch and Generational Mobility Regimes

The age gap. The broker survey respondents have a median age of approximately 69 years (born roughly 1940–1965), whereas EMOVI 2021 covers adults aged 25–64 (born roughly 1957–1996). The two populations therefore exhibit only partial birth-cohort overlap. We evaluate below whether this age mismatch compromises the comparison.

The “completed mobility” assumption. The comparison rests on the premise that intergenerational social mobility is largely *completed* by age 40: educational transitions, first occupation, and initial household formation — the primary channels through which origin status transmits to destination status — are mostly resolved within the first two decades of adulthood. If this is true, then comparing the *outcomes* of older and younger cohorts who completed their mobility in different decades is valid, provided the process itself was similar across generations.

The timing assumption is well-supported. Standard mobility research uses age-40 outcomes as the benchmark for long-run socioeconomic attainment, and the EMOVI methodology itself targets 25–64 year-olds on the premise that most adults in that range have completed primary transitions (Centro de Estudios Espinosa Yglesias, 2021). Our poverty index relies on asset stocks (education attainment, housing characteristics, durable goods) rather than current income flows, which further reduces life-cycle bias: asset stocks are relatively stable past middle age, making a 70-year-old and a 50-year-old with similar childhood origins more comparable on our index than on current income.

Where the assumption is weaker. The *process* assumption is more contested. Research by Torche (Torche, 2020) using cohort analysis of EMOVI data finds non-linear trends: intergenerational persistence increased for cohorts born in the 1950s through the early 1970s, then declined for post-1970 cohorts, suggesting that different generations operated under qualitatively different mobility regimes. Two structural breaks are especially relevant for Nuevo León:

- *ISI-era industrial expansion (1950s–1970s)*: The Monterrey metropolitan area underwent rapid industrialization during the import-substitution industrialization (ISI) period, generating substantial upward mobility for working-class cohorts entering manufacturing during that era (Balán et al., 1973). Brokers born 1940–1965 reached their primary mobility window (ages 20–40) precisely during this period of peak structural opportunity. Younger cohorts in the EMOVI sample did not.
- *Post-crisis structural closure (1980s–present)*: The 1982 debt crisis and subsequent deindustrialization reduced occupational achievement opportunities across all strata (Escobar Latapí and González de la Rocha, 1995). ESRU-EMOVI 2021 data for Nuevo León show that downward mobility now exceeds upward mobility for the younger cohorts captured in the survey (de la Torre and Espinosa Montiel, 2021).

Direction of bias. The asymmetric generational advantage of older cohorts implies that, all else equal, brokers benefited from a more favorable structural mobility environment than the EMOVI comparison population. If mobility regimes differ, any observed similarities between brokers and EMOVI respondents in current socioeconomic status most likely *understate* broker disadvantage: brokers attained similar outcomes despite facing the same working-class origins under a more favorable structural regime, while younger EMOVI respondents faced a more closed structure. The cross-cohort comparison is therefore *conservative* with respect to the paper’s main argument that brokers are not economically selected from the upper stratum of their communities.

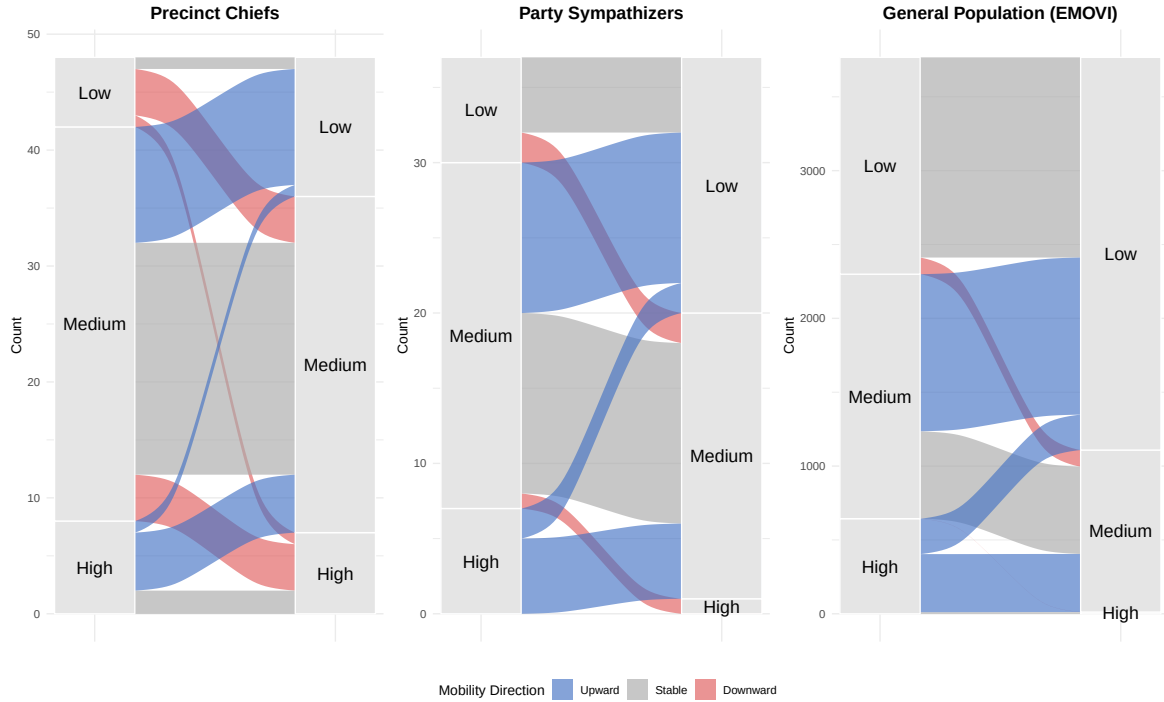
Survivor selection. A related concern is that the broker population, with a median age of 69, represents surviving members of their birth cohort. Given the correlation between poverty and mortality in Mexico, the poorest members of older cohorts are disproportionately likely to have died before 2021, making surviving brokers a positively selected subsample relative to their full birth cohort. This again stacks the cards against the broker disadvantage we document.

Summary. We conclude that the cross-cohort comparison is defensible, with the important caveat that any differences between brokers and the EMOVI reference population likely *understate* broker disadvantage. We report the EMOVI comparison as a descriptive benchmark rather than a causal estimate, and readers should interpret apparent similarities in socioeconomic outcomes as a lower bound on broker community embeddedness.

A.9.3 Variant Figures: EMOVI Inclusion and Full-Population Robustness

Figure A.2 reproduces the poverty mobility Sankey of Figure 6 in the main text with the EMOVI panel restored. The EMOVI panel is informative for upward transitions and within-tier persistence, but it understates High-poverty persistence by construction: under the binary bathroom recoding (Section A.6), approximately 97% of EMOVI respondents in Nuevo León hold at least one bathroom at both time points, leaving less than 1% of the weighted sample in the High poverty tier. We therefore exclude EMOVI from Figure 6 in the main text and present it here as a supplementary figure.

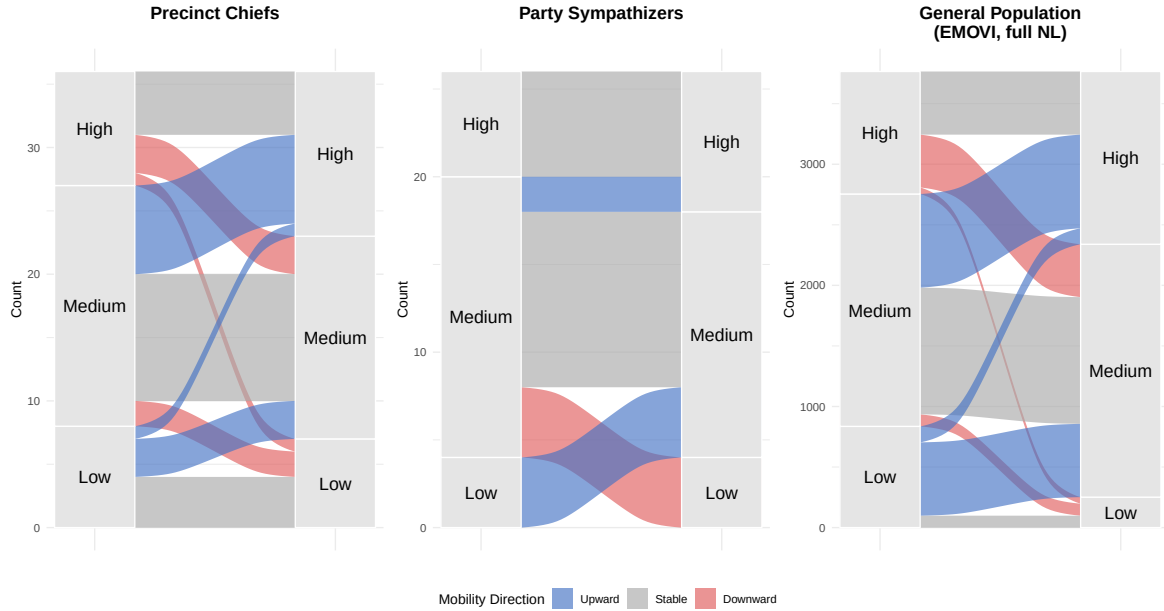
Figure A.2: Poverty mobility with EMOVI panel (supplementary)



Notes: Three-panel Sankey: Precinct Chiefs ($N = 53$), Party Sympathizers ($N = 37$), and EMOVI 2021 reweighted with `factor_broker_pop` (six broker municipalities, $N = 785$ active respondents; calibrated to 34% male using the full *jefes seccionales* roster). Origin (age 14) to destination (current) by poverty index tier. Index construction as in Section A.6; see caveat in the surrounding text on the EMOVI High-poverty tier. *Origin–destination percentages* (rows: origin poverty tier; entries: % to Low / Medium / High at destination). Precinct Chiefs: Low $\rightarrow$ 17/67/17; Medium $\rightarrow$ 29/59/12; High $\rightarrow$ 12/62/25. Party Sympathizers: Low $\rightarrow$ 71/29/0; Medium $\rightarrow$ 44/52/4; High $\rightarrow$ 29/71/0. EMOVI (`factor_broker_pop`): Low $\rightarrow$ 92/8/0; Medium $\rightarrow$ 64/36/0; High $\rightarrow$ 37/61/2 (the near-zero High-tier entries reflect the bathroom-recoding artifact described above).

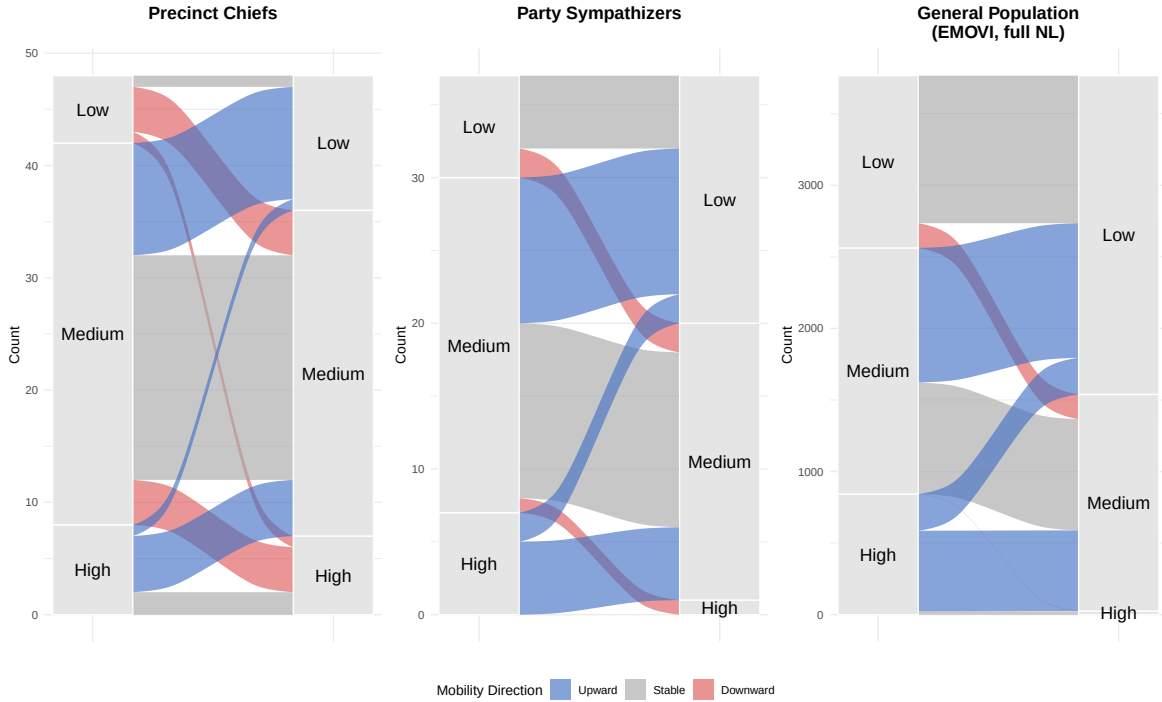
Figures A.3 and A.4 report the same economic and poverty Sankeys computed with the original EMOVI design weight (`factor_emovi`, unfiltered), covering the full Nuevo León adult population aged 25–64. Because the unfiltered EMOVI is not restricted to the six broker municipalities and is not gender-calibrated to the broker roster, it is not the most demographically comparable benchmark. We include these variants as a robustness check: the qualitative patterns documented in the main text are not driven by the municipality restriction or by the gender re-calibration.

Figure A.3: Economic mobility, full Nuevo León adult population (robustness)



Notes: EMOVI panel uses the original survey design weight (`factor_emovi`) with no municipality restriction and no gender re-calibration; full NL adult population aged 25–64 ($N = 3,767$). Broker and sympathizer panels unchanged from Figure 5. Variables and tercile cutoffs as in Figure 5 (main text). *Origin–destination percentages.* Brokers and party sympathizers: see Figure 5 notes. EMOVI (`factor_emovi`, full NL): Low $\rightarrow$ 12/72/16; Medium $\rightarrow$ 5/54/40; High $\rightarrow$ 5/43/52.

Figure A.4: Poverty mobility, full Nuevo León adult population (robustness)



Notes: EMOVI panel uses the original survey design weight (`factor_emovi`) with no municipality restriction and no gender re-calibration; full NL adult population aged 25–64 ($N = 3,767$). Broker and sympathizer panels unchanged from Figure 6. Index construction as in Section A.6; same bathroom-tier caveat applies as in Figure A.2. *Origin–destination percentages.* Brokers and party sympathizers: see Figure 6 notes. EMOVI (`factor_emovi`, full NL): Low $\rightarrow 86/14/0$; Medium $\rightarrow 55/45/0$; High $\rightarrow 30/67/3$.

A.10 Privacy and Data Protection Compliance

The survey data contained personal information (telephone numbers) of Mexican citizens, which are protected under Mexican data privacy law. Following legal consultation, we determined that provisions of the previous data protection law applied to our case, specifically regarding indirect data collection. As the contact information was obtained through a third party in 2014, explicit consent was required from each respondent for data use.

The survey protocol included informing respondents about the indirect source of their contact information and obtaining verbal consent for participation. Respondents were assured that refusal to participate would result in immediate deletion of their personal information from all project

records. An institutional contact number was provided for respondents seeking additional information about data handling or wishing to withdraw consent post-interview.